DD-254 Interactive

User Manual

Preparing, validating, issuing and tracking DD Form 254

DD254 Interactive v2.14.0 (tool version 2.160)

Runs entirely in your browser. No server, no network, no login.
All data is local to this machine and this browser profile.

DD254 Interactive v2.14.0 changes

- **The language rail is always beside the form.** It used to be a tab you could close, and closing it was remembered — so you could go on issuing DD-254s without ever seeing the wording your own templates hold. There is no tab and nothing to reopen. On a narrow screen it gets narrower; it never disappears, and it is still never printed.
- **Standard Language and Contract Templates That Fit have left the right-hand panel.** Both were listed in two places and only the rail could insert from them. The rail now carries the whole of what that panel did — what the list was narrowed to and why, the entries written for something else one link away, and the opening words of each — so you insert where you are already reading. See 5.6.
- **Contract language can be applied from the rail**, by the same route the template picker above the form uses. It asks before it replaces anything.
- **Each piece of template language either always applies, or waits for its box.** You choose which beside the wording itself, where there used to be a tick-box called “always insert”. Always-language is written into every DD-254 built from that template, and unticking the box does not take it back out, because the box was never what put it there. Everything else stays out until its own Item 10 or 11 box is ticked on the form.

1. The checklist that asked which caveats applied when a DD-254 was created is gone. It was a second place the same clause could be switched off, and a clause that can be suppressed from two places is one that quietly fails to appear. The box on the form is the trigger.

- **Fixed:** per-box template language now works on a DD-254 created from a matched template. The draft never recorded which template it came from, so ticking 11d afterwards inserted nothing and the feature looked as though it did not exist.
- **A contract template says what it is for on its own row** — its name, programme, scenario and Item 1a level, as four controls, the way a standard language row has had them. The level and scenario moved out of Edit blocks rather than being duplicated onto the row, so each still has exactly one control.
- **The requester e-mail searches the requesters you have on file** and fills in the first and last name from the one you pick. An address nobody has used says so, and its listing is created along with the DD-254. A name you typed yourself is never written over, and an address two people share names them both rather than choosing. See 3.18.

DD254 Interactive v2.13.0 changes

- **The tool now works out which contract templates fit the DD-254 in front of you.** A template records a programme, an **Item 1a level** and whether it is written for a **purchase** or for **bids**. All three can be left as Any or Either, and a template you saved before this version reads as Any on every one of them — nothing vanishes from your library.
- **A new Contract Templates That Fit panel** sits beside the form listing only the ones that match, each with an Apply button, and a link to the rest saying how many are written for something else. It is the same panel Standard Language has always had.
- **Capturing a form into a template records its Item 1a level**, so a captured template knows what it was written for without being told.

2. The Item 1a level is not the CUI marking. A template marked CUI is still offered at every clearance level; they were never the same question.
3. Nothing was removed. Task orders and their coverage, source provenance and revision tracking, and duplicate detection all behave exactly as before.

DD254 Interactive v2.12.0 changes

- **The official export is the dynamic XFA form, and only that.** The flat print-to-PDF writer and its embedded copy of the form are gone, which makes the tool 762 KB smaller. Note that an XFA form cannot be digitally signed in the free Adobe Reader without Reader Extensions usage rights, so signing needs Acrobat.
- **Item 13 is plain text.** The bold and underline buttons are gone, and pasting from Word now brings the words without the formatting.
- **The issuance e-mail lists what must travel with the form.** Every required attachment is named in the prepared message, once per audience group, with a **Copy Attachments** button beside Copy To and Copy CC. If the list is too long for the e-mail link it is left out rather than cut in half, and the window says so. See 3.13.
- **Template attachments are one name per box** instead of one text area, so a line wrap or a pasted note can no longer become a phantom attachment.
- **Copying asks what the copy is.** One window: Original or Solicitation, with the requester, contract, order and Security Manager already filled in. A matching template never overwrites the language you copied, and the Item 3 dates start empty.
- **The standalone task-order box follows the order.** It is ticked when that order has a DD-254 of its own and never when the order runs under the prime's.
- **Standard language goes to the top or the bottom of Item 13**, your choice in Settings, and top-placed language stays above the Item 10 and 11 sections. The classified mailing address stays last either way. See 2.5.
- **Purchase and bids wording are separate sets.** A solicitation is offered bids language and an award purchase language. Anything written before this counts as either, so nothing disappears.
- **A language banner** beside the form carries what this DD-254 may actually use. It started closed in this release; since v2.14.0 it is always open and cannot be hidden. It is never printed.
- **Template caveats are taken back out when their box is unticked**, and an edited caveat is left alone and flagged rather than half-deleted. This release also asked which caveats applied when the DD-254 was created; v2.14.0 removed that question, because the box on the form was already the answer.
- **An optional acquisition caveat engine**, off unless you turn it on, asks what is being bought and works out 11c against 11d, the COMSEC and OPSEC consequences, and whether a classified mailing address is required. It advises; nothing changes until you apply it. See 2.5.

DD254 Interactive v2.11.0 changes

- **The issuance e-mail now tells two groups apart.** The **To** line is everyone the DD-254 has to reach and you cannot switch any of them off: the requestor, the **Item 7** FSO of the receiving facility, every **Item 8** performance-location FSO, the cognizant security office, and anyone written into **Block 18f**. See 3.13.
- **Who else is copied is now yours to choose. Manage** → **Settings** gains *Who is copied on an issuance* — the **Security Manager** and the **Item 6 FSO**, the two the tool works out for itself. **Both start switched off**, so after upgrading they stop being e-mailed until you turn them on. FSOs you type in by hand, and managers you add with **Add to CC**, are always copied: you chose those on the form itself. See 2.5.
- **A DD-254 can no longer be issued while somebody it must reach has no address.** The message names each one, and names a performance site by its location. A requirement only applies where the form asks for it, so an Item 7 naming no subcontractor is not a gap and a prime DD-254 is unaffected.
- **Full Backup carries your settings.** A restore offers them and applies them only if you accept. Older backup files still verify unchanged.

DD254 Interactive v2.10.0 changes

- **Creating a DD-254 asks for the work, not just a title.** One dialog collects the requester's first name, last name and e-mail, the prime contract or vehicle, an optional task order, and a Security Manager. An **Original** also requires **Block 2b** — the subcontract number, or **N/A**. A **Solicitation** also requires **Block 2c** and its **due date**. See 3.18.
- **Requesters** are kept under **Manage** → **Requesters**, with a count of how many of their DD-254s have been issued. Typing a known name fills in their e-mail; it never overwrites one you typed, and two people of the same name are never chosen between.
- **The numbers you type are matched against your templates.** An exact task-order match wins over a prime-only one, a single match is named and applied whole, several matches are never chosen between, and a partial match is only a suggestion. What you typed always wins over what the template carries.
- **The Security Manager is kept on the DD-254 itself** and appears directly below the requester at issuance, on the **To** line. Editing the Security Manager repository afterwards does not change a DD-254 already made. **The Item 6 facility FSO moved from CC to To** with this change.

DD254 Interactive v2.9.1 changes

- The **Standard Language** list now shows **what this DD-254 calls for** — the entries written for its programme and its Item 1a level — instead of the whole library. **Show all** opens the rest. Until the form has both a programme and a level, every entry is listed with a line saying what would narrow it. See 5.6.

DD254 Interactive v2.9.0 changes

- **Naming a new DD-254. New Solicitation** and **Original** now ask for the **person's first and last name**, the **prime contract number**, an optional **subcontract number** and an **e-mail**, instead of a free-text title. The name is built as *Jane Doe — N00178-24-D-1234* and stays editable. The contract numbers go to Items 2a and 2b and the e-mail becomes the requestor, so none of them is typed twice. The **pencil** reopens the same fields. See 3.18.
- **The dashboard card gains a DD-254 template picker** beside its contract type one, and **both are now searchable** — type part of a contract or order number and the list narrows. The template picker lists task orders under their own number, and an order that follows its prime resolves to the prime's template. Choosing applies that language to that DD-254. See 3.17.
- **Fixed:** the template picker on the form now lists **every saved order** under its own number. An order that follows the prime used to be absent, so searching its order number found nothing and you had to remember which prime covered it. Choosing one inserts the prime's template, and the entry says which template that is. An order with no prime template saved yet is shown but cannot be chosen.
- **Task orders can be deleted**, and an order's coverage can be **changed after creation** — from its own DD-254 to following the prime, or the other way. Deleting keeps the order-specific template and any DD-254 already created from the order. Moving an order to its own DD-254 starts an editable template from the prime's language; moving it to the prime keeps its own template in the library, unbound. Either way the order asks for its source to be reviewed before a new DD-254 is started from it.
- **Standard language is now inserted for you** when it is mandatory. The programme comes from the language applied to the DD-254 and the level from Item 1a, so a CONFIDENTIAL DD-254 on a programme that has a CONFIDENTIAL entry gets that entry automatically. Two matching entries are never chosen for you: the blocking error names both and you insert the one that applies. The question asked at creation in v2.8.0 is gone. See 5.6.

DD254 Interactive v2.8.0 changes

- **Settings: Standard language** can now be **Mandatory** instead of Optional. Mandatory offers a new DD-254 the Standard Language entry that matches its programme and its Item 1a level, and a DD-254 whose Item 13 carries none of the library wording cannot leave Draft. What is checked is what is in Item 13, so deleting the paragraph removes it. The offer can be declined; the blocking error then stands until the wording is there, and like any other finding it can be set aside with a written reason. See 2.5 and 5.6.
- **Standard Language** entries carry an optional **programme** and **Item 1a level**, which is what lets the right entry be offered. Blank means the entry fits any programme or any level. See 5.6.
- **Fixed:** the Contract Type repository showed a security / program manager box with no picker behind it — the list was built only for DD-254 Template Language. Both repositories now offer it.
- **Programme** options in the Contract Type, DD-254 Template Language and Standard Language repositories are taken from the **Security Manager templates**, instead of from whatever had already been typed into the repository being edited. A programme already recorded on a template stays in the list. See 5.5.

DD254 Interactive v2.7.2 changes

- **Fixed:** copying a DD-254 no longer brings its workflow with it. A copy of a blocked DD-254 used to arrive carrying the original's holds — raised against the original, dated before the copy existed — along with its distribution record and countersignature, so the copy showed a queue it had never been in. Status, holds, distribution, countersignature and the issue and review dates now stay with the DD-254 they happened to. If the copy's own Item 10, 11 or 14 boxes call for GCA approval it raises its own hold, dated today. See 3.4.

DD254 Interactive v2.7.1 changes

- **Fixed:** a task order with its own DD-254 now appears in the template picker on the form, listed by its prime contract and order number. Choosing it selects the template bound to that order. An order whose source still needs review is shown but cannot be chosen. See 5.3.
- **Corrected:** Item 11j cited DoDD 5205.02E for the rule that Item 14 must be YES. That requirement is in the **DD Form 254 Instructions, Item 11j(1)**, which also calls for the pertinent contract clauses to be identified and clarifying guidance added to Item 13. DoDD 5205.02E is the DoD OPSEC programme directive; it is not what obliges Item 14. What the tool asks of you has not changed.

DD254 Interactive v2.7.0 changes

- Creating a solicitation or an Original **no longer asks you to pick a contract type**. Most contracts are ordinary FAR-based ones that have none, so the question is gone from origination.
- Contract vehicles that carry their own boilerplate now have a **Contract Type** picker of their own, in the Checklist and Templates panel above DD-254 Template Language. Choose one when the contract calls for it; applying it fills Items 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16 and 18 and still asks before replacing Block 13 text. See 5.5.

DD254 Interactive v2.6.0 changes

- Every DD Form 254 now carries **Please direct all questions to the prime contractor.** in Item 13, directly above the classified mailing addresses. It is added to an existing DD-254 when you open it, and maintained with the addresses rather than typed by hand. An **Issued** DD-254 is never changed — it is the record of what went out — and nor are Cancelled or Skipped ones; move one back to Draft, Ready to sign or Blocked and it gains the line next time you open it. A Revision does not report Item 13 as revised just because of this line. See 4.12.
- **Contract Type** templates now have the same **Program** field as DD-254 Template Language entries. Assigning a security manager fills it from that manager. See 5.5.

- **Fixed:** applying a template that carried a task order always ticked **This outgoing DD Form 254 is specific to the order above**, so Block 2a exported the contract and the task order together even when the order was covered by the prime's DD-254. A template that does not record that choice no longer makes one. See 4.5.

DD254 Interactive v2.5.0 changes

- Both Contracting Officer review packages now open with a **Contract authority** table: each Item 2 number separately, the issuance stage, and the classification guides cited in Item 13. A guide whose cited date differs from the one you hold is flagged. **Fixed:** the package used to show a single contract number, so on a subcontract it showed the prime number and hid the subcontract number. See 6.1.
- The **government** package also lists Items 16a to 16f, showing what is entered or **To be completed by the GCA**. The prime package does not: Item 16 is the GCA's block. Nothing about this changes what the tool requires of you — a blank Item 16 still raises no error. See 4.11 and 6.1.

DD254 Interactive v2.4.1 changes

- Choose prime or task-order-specific DD254 coverage only when creating a task order. Saved orders show their coverage as a label; there are no coverage-switching buttons. Reviewing a changed or newer DD254 stays within the coverage chosen for that order.

DD254 Interactive v2.4.0 changes

- **Add template** creates a prime-contract DD254 template with its Block 2A number, name and program. New prime templates appear first. The repository retains the existing editable rows, toolbar and block editor. All matching contracts and orders remain on one continuously scrolling page; prime groups can still be collapsed.
- **Add task order** beneath a prime creates a Task Order, BPA or Delivery Order with the inherited prime number. Choose **Use prime DD254** for a compact entry that follows the prime, or **Use task-order-specific DD254** for an independent, fully editable DD254 template beneath it. Both prime and own templates have the same block fields. Coverage is selected in the creation form and stays with the saved order.
- Each template has a **Program** field. Filter by program while retaining searches for prime contract and order numbers. Sort by newest first, contract number or program. **Find duplicates** flags repeated prime-contract/order identities, even when the names or language differ. Shared language on different contracts or orders is not a duplicate.
- **Create DD254** starts an Original from the selected DD254; **Open DD254** reopens a linked workflow. Source edits still require review before new work starts. Saved source versions and existing outgoing workflows retain their wording. The outgoing order-specific checkbox remains a separate preparer choice. Full Backup and language JSON retain orders and source history; CSV retains template rows, including their program.

DD254 Interactive v2.2.0 changes

- Performance-location FSOs and the subcontractor FSO appear on **To** with the requestor. Facility FSOs, CSOs and selected security or program security managers appear on **CC**. Item 18 offers a manager dropdown from the Security Managers repository. The assigned template manager is included automatically, and selections travel with the draft.
- **Save this language template** at Item 18 names and saves the current language without leaving the workflow. Whole-template insertion now replaces represented sections completely, including blanks, unchecked boxes and empty radio selections. The confirmation explains this before applying.
- The DD-254 Template Language repository keeps its existing editable rows. Prime contract and task-order filters, optional grouping and **Find duplicates** help organise a large library. Inline warnings and **Compare** help review possible copies. The current release limits duplicate flags to repeated prime-contract/order identities.

DD254 Interactive v2.1.2 changes

- The ready-to-issue dialog includes required attachments from both the Contract Type and DD-254 Template Language templates. Its CUI notice follows the document marking; the on-form warning about a contract involving CUI remains.

DD254 Interactive v2.1.1 changes

- **Fixed:** the certifying official linked to a facility only reached Item 17 while a facility template was being applied by CAGE, so Item 17 stayed blank on a DD-254 you opened, typed by hand or spawned as a Revision or Final. Item 17 is now also filled from the CAGE already in **Item 6b** — when you open a draft, and when you finish entering that field. It fills only when Item 17 is completely empty, so anything you have entered is left alone. See 5.3.

DD254 Interactive v2.1.0 changes

- A **Facility** template can name the **certifying official** who signs Item 17 for it. Choose one from the second dropdown on the facility row; applying that facility by CAGE then fills Items 17a, 17b, 17c, 17e, 17f and 17g as well as Item 6. A facility with no official linked leaves Item 17 exactly as it is. See 5.1 and 5.3.

DD254 Interactive v2.0.3 changes

- The window title, the form header and the release line on review-package PDFs now show the product name, **DD254 Interactive**, with the version. Nothing else changes.

DD254 Interactive v2.0.2 changes

- Each **Security Classification Guide** can be linked to contracts from the DD-254 Template Language library. On a form for one of those contracts, its guides are listed first and marked **Linked to this contract**. See 5.9.
- A new setting makes the reason **optional** for setting a finding aside, marking a DD-254 Blocked and cancelling one. It is off by default; with it on, a blank reason is recorded as **No reason given** and the action is still in the audit log. See 2.5.

DD254 Interactive v2.0.1 changes

- A Revision or Final keeps the **original date in Item 3a**, taken from the Original, and both PDFs now print it. A missing or changed original date is a blocking error. See 3.3.
- Revisions are **numbered 1, 2, 3** within each Original. A spawned Revision takes the next number not already held by a Revision that is not cancelled, and the revision number must be a whole number.
- An Original spawned from a Solicitation starts with Item 3a empty, because the award has its own signature date.

DD254 Interactive v2.0.0 changes

- **Restoring a Full Backup no longer deletes newer templates.** The restore shows what it would change in each library, then merges: templates in both return to the backup's version, templates only in the backup are added, and templates you created since are kept. Replacing every list is still available as a separate choice, after a backup of what you have now. See 8.1.
- **Fixed: Undo last change** after importing a colleague's templates emptied that library instead of reverting it. It now puts the library back as it was.

DD254 Interactive v1.16.0 changes

- The Contracting Officer Package is now two review packages, one for the **Government CO / GCA** and one for a **prime contractor issuing a subcontract**. The tool picks one from Items 2b and 7a and lets you choose the other, on screen or as a PDF. See 6.1.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.7 changes

- **Corrected:** 3.14 attributed the dashboard's review clock to DoDI 5220.22. The clock follows the DD Form 254 Instructions, Item 3b(3), which call for a biennial review of revisions. The Government Contracting Activity's own biennial review is a separate government duty, now in DoDM 5220.32 Volume 1, and the Contracting Officer package says so.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.6 changes

- A card can carry the contract's **period of performance end date**, a tool-only date that never prints. Before it, and before the two-year retention window after it closes, the card prompts at 120, 60 and 30 days until a Final is issued. See 3.14.
- The demonstration build opens with an example portfolio: fictitious DD-254s in every status, so its features can be seen without building a chain first.
- **Fixed:** a note or other change saved while the dashboard was redrawing could be overwritten on an older draft. The dashboard now updates only what it needs to on the stored record.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.5 changes

- The **countersignature** badge now appears only on a SAP subcontract: the SAP flag with a subcontractor in Item 2b or 7a. It used to appear on every spawned Original, Revision or Final, including Revisions of prime contracts. See 3.11.
- A contract is SAP or non-SAP for its whole life. A spawned Original, Revision or Final whose SAP flag differs from the issuance it was spawned from is a blocking error. See 2.2.
- The Item 17 help text no longer says every subcontract needs the subcontractor's signature; that is a SAP rule (DoDM 5205.07 section 10.1.d). The Preparer's Worksheet now treats a SAP subcontractor named only in Item 7a as a SAP subcontract, as the rest of the tool already did.
- **Redraft** on a revision summary can compare with any earlier issuance in the chain, such as the Original, not only the one the Revision was spawned from. See 4.20.
- **Fixed:** a long confirmation, such as the review of missing Item 13 language, ran off the screen with its buttons out of reach. Every dialog now fits the window and scrolls inside.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.4 changes

- A Revision spawned on the dashboard gets a **summary of changes** at the top of Item 13 the first time it is opened, kept up to date as you change the form, so the contracting officer incorporating the revision sees what changed on the form itself. See 4.20.
- A Revision whose only changes are point-of-contact details in Items 16d-16f or 17a-17g now raises a warning, following the DD Form 254 instructions.
- **Fixed:** the flow-down ceiling compared a spawned Original, Revision or Final with its own earlier issuance as if that were the prime contract, so a Revision that raised Item 1a or 1b was blocked with a subcontract error. Issuances of the same contract are no longer compared that way.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.3 changes

- **Manage, then Sensitive terms** keeps a list of unclassified program nicknames or other words that should not appear on a DD Form 254. Items 9 and 13 are checked against it and a match raises a warning. The list is stored only as one-way fingerprints: it cannot be viewed, exported, backed up or shared. See 4.19.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.2 changes

- A ninth library, **Security Classification Guides**, keeps each guide's unclassified title, identifier, date, issuing office, distribution statement and delivery method. **Cite** in the form's side panel adds one citation line to Item 13, and cited guides are named in the attachment reminder. If a guide's date changes in the library, a draft still citing the old date gets a warning and an **Update citation** button. See 5.9.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.1 changes

- **Import received DD 254 (PDF)** on the DD-254 Template Language page turns a fillable DD Form 254 you received into a new template entry: its Items 10 to 16 and 18, its classification marking, and its Item 3 source type and date. Nothing else is created — no draft, no dashboard card — and the PDF is not kept. See 5.4.

DD254 Interactive v1.15.0 changes

- Each dashboard card labels its numbers: **Prime** (Item 2a), **Subcontract** (Item 2b) and **Solicitation** (Item 2c), whichever are filled, beside the contractor and the subcontractor CAGE — see 3.1.
- Search takes several terms in any order. **pat.requestor 5XYZ5 W911NF** finds the DD-254 carrying all three, however you type them; a contract number matches with or without its hyphens — see 3.10.
- Spawning an Original, Revision or Final no longer carries NISS verification into the new DD-254. Its card shows **NISS re-confirm** until you verify again for that issuance — see 3.3 and 3.11.

DD254 Interactive v1.14.1 changes

A correction release. Nothing about how a DD Form 254 is validated, held or exported changed.

- The header shows the release name from the tool itself, so it always matches the file you downloaded. The OMB expiry date now sits beside the OMB number it belongs to.
- The Preparer's Worksheet and the Contracting Officer Package name Item 14 **Additional Security Requirements** and Item 15 **Inspections**, as the form does.
- The Contracting Officer Package no longer has signature or date lines. Sign Item 17h and date Item 17i in the generated dynamic PDF — see 6.1. A SAP subcontract named only in Item 7a now gets the subcontractor-signature requirement in the package.
- Opening a draft saved by an earlier version that still holds log entries, attached files or supporting records now tells you first — see 3.16.
- Validation counts on the cards refresh automatically after an update — see 3.15.
- The demonstration build's sample language now cites verified authorities.

DD254 Interactive v1.14.0 changes

The Source & Validation Log and the Optional supporting records panel have been removed. Both recorded the preparer's working material — sources consulted, notes, attached files, review questions, requirement costs and closeout records — which is not needed to prepare or issue the DD Form 254, and neither printed on the form. Drafts saved by earlier versions still open; any log entries, attachments or supporting records they contain are no longer shown and are not written back when the draft is saved. To keep that material, export it from v1.13.0 before opening the draft in this version. The Final-form retention guidance those records carried remains in the Item 3 instructions, the Item 3c validation note and the CO package.

Drafting shortcuts in v1.12.0

- At Item 8, choose **Use Item 6 contractor as a performance site** or the Item 7 equivalent when that entity is a classified performance location. The action copies the entered location, CAGE, CSO and FSO e-mail, plus Item 7 CMA when present. It fills an empty row or adds one. Matching location/CAGE entries are not duplicated or overwritten. This does not verify eligibility or safeguarding.
- Choose **Go to field** beside a validation finding to open its form step and focus the entry. **Go to next incomplete field** opens the first detected, navigable finding. Relevant text fields display their existing error messages beside the entry. These controls use the existing validator; they are not a complete legal review.
- At Item 13, choose **Review language for missing selected sections**. One preview collects existing saved or built-in templates for selected Items 10/11 whose sections are empty. Confirm to insert them together, or cancel to leave the form unchanged. Populated sections and unselected items are skipped. Changes during preview require a new preview.
- **Find next unfinished prompt** selects the next recognized bracketed template prompt, such as [INSERT APPLICABLE AUTHORITY], in the Item 13 editor. Repeated clicks move through the prompts. This advisory recognizes common template markers; it cannot identify every missing fact or validate an authority. Complete and verify the text yourself.

Retained v1.10.0 safeguards

Dashboard notes now preserve quick edits across multiple cards and keep pending text visible when the dashboard redraws. Full Backup saves pending notes, the active form and template edits before building its snapshot. If you make further changes while the backup is being created or confirmed, their reminder remains active.

A failed individual IndexedDB draft write now keeps the newest copy in the open tab and includes it in Full Backup. A failed database read stops the backup instead of producing a misleading empty portfolio. Keep the tab open when the storage warning appears; an emergency copy is not persistent storage.

The warning beside the classification selector now describes the tool's processing limit accurately. Release downloads, test results, the demonstration build and the component manifest are checked together. Previous versioned files remain available.

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1. What this tool is

DD-254 Interactive is a single HTML file that runs entirely inside your browser. There is no server, no login and no network traffic: everything you type stays on the machine you typed it on, in that browser's local storage. Opening the file from a different browser, a different Windows profile, or a colleague's laptop shows an empty workspace.

Two consequences follow, and they govern everything else in this manual:

1. Your drafts and templates are only as safe as your last backup. Nothing is stored anywhere else. Section 9 explains how.
2. The tool is single-user by design. Two people cannot collaborate inside one file. Managers consolidate a team by importing each person's backup read-only — section 8.

> This tool supports UNCLASSIFIED or CUI entries only and is not approved for classified processing. A DD Form 254 can itself contain classified information under the official form instructions; prepare such a form on an approved system. Never enter classified content or upload classified attachments in this tool.

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2. Before you start

2.1 Set the classification marking

The top bar carries a **Classification when filled in** selector. Leave it at UNCLASSIFIED, or switch to CUI. This drives the banner at the top and bottom of the screen, the marking stamped on every page of every exported PDF, the marking on the first row of every exported CSV, and the encryption warning shown when you record distribution.

2.2 Flag a SAP DD-254

Beside the classification selector is a **SAP DD-254** toggle. Leave it off unless this form is administered under a Special Access Program. It is off by default and it never prints on the form.

Everything in the tool that cites DoDM 5205.07 — most visibly the requirement that a subcontractor's authorised representative sign the DD Form 254 — appears only when this is set. Those are Special Access Program rules; on an ordinary subcontract they do not apply, and the tool no longer raises them.

> A contract is SAP or non-SAP for its whole life. On an Original, Revision or Final spawned on the dashboard, a SAP flag that differs from the issuance it was spawned from is a blocking error: either the flag is wrong, or the work is a different contract and belongs on a new DD-254.

2.3 One tab only

If you open the tool in a second tab or window, that tab goes read-only and shows a full-screen notice. This is deliberate. Template lists are saved as a whole, so two tabs editing at once would silently destroy one another's work with no error message.

The read-only tab offers **Use this tab instead**, which hands the lock over and puts the other tab into read-only mode, and **Reload**. If a tab crashes, its lock expires after a few seconds and the next tab reclaims it automatically.

2.4 Where the work lives

The tool has two views. The **DD-254 Workspace Dashboard** is your queue — every DD-254 you are working on. The form itself takes one DD-254 at a time. Opening a draft from the dashboard takes you into the form with that record loaded, and **Dashboard** at the top left goes back.

2.5 Settings

Manage then **Settings** opens a panel of preferences. It replaces the draft list while it is open, and closing it brings the list back. The panel is built from the tool’s own registry of settings rather than a fixed list, so what you see is what this build actually supports.

Setting	What it controls
Form layout	**One page** puts every wizard step on the page at once. **Step by step** shows one step at a time. The floating form button and this row always agree.
Item 13 layout	**One block** is the classic free-text box. **Sections** gives a box per ticked Item 10 or 11 entry — see 4.16.
Theme	Light or dark. Dark applies to the tool chrome only: the DD-254 facsimile, the print stylesheet and every export are untouched.
Workspace width	Reading, wide, full-window or a custom width set by dragging the dashboard edge. It changes the workspace only, never the DD-254 facsimile.
Text size	Compact, standard or large text for the application workspace. It does not change the form or exported documents.
Reasons for set-aside, Blocked and Cancel	**Required** (the default) asks why whenever you set a finding aside, mark a DD-254 Blocked or cancel one. **Optional** lets you leave the reason blank for people who do not need the audit trail. The action is still written to the audit log, marked **No reason given**, and switching the setting either way is logged too.
Backup reminder	How many unsaved changes may accumulate before the reminder warns you. The default reproduces the previous behaviour, and it cannot be switched off entirely.
Who is copied on an issuance	Whether the **Security Manager** and the **Item 6 FSO** go on the **CC** line of every issuance e-mail. Both start off. Addresses you typed in by hand, and managers you added with **Add to CC**, are always copied and are not listed here. Nor is the **To** line, because it is not a choice — see 3.13.
Your name	Recorded on template packs and read by the manager rollup. Changeable here without clearing site data.
Export filename	Which fields make up an exported file name, in what order, with which separator — see 6.5.

> Dark theme is deliberately absent from anything printed or exported. A reviewer opening your PDF sees the same document whichever theme you work in.

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3. The dashboard — working your queue

3.1 Reading a card

Each DD-254 is a card. The coloured border around the card is its status. A card turns grey once a revision or final has been spawned from it — grey means superseded, and the live status has moved to the newer card indented beneath it.

The card line labels each contract number the form carries: **Prime** from Item 2a, **Subcontract** from Item 2b and **Solicitation** from Item 2c. Only filled items appear, so a subcontract shows its prime and subcontract numbers together and a solicitation shows its solicitation number. After them come the contractor and — when Item 7b is filled — **Subcontractor CAGE**.

3.2 Statuses

Status	Meaning
Draft	Being prepared. Forced automatically whenever validation errors exist.
Blocked	Waiting on someone else, or on an approval. Requires a documented hold — see 3.6 and 3.7.
Ready to sign	Complete and validated, awaiting certification.
Issued	Signed and distributed.
Skipped	Solicitations only. The customer went straight to an Original, so this solicitation was never issued and never will be. Counted under Issued as closed-out work.
Cancelled	Any stage. Requires a documented reason unless reasons are optional in Settings (2.5). Leaves the working list — see 3.6.

The chips along the top count each status and act as filters — click one to show only those cards, click again to clear. They run in the order work moves: **Draft, Blocked, Ready to sign, Issued, Cancelled**, then Total and the average draft-to-issue time. Skipped folds into the Issued chip.

Awaiting info was retired. It meant the same thing as Blocked and split the queue for no reason. Any record still sitting on it is moved to Blocked when the dashboard loads, keeping its holds and history, and the change is written to the audit log.

3.3 Stages and the revision chain

A record carries a stage: Solicitation, Original, Revision or Final. From a Solicitation you can spawn an Original; from an Original or Revision you can spawn a Revision or a Final. Spawned cards nest under their parent, keeping the whole chain for one contract together. **Compare** walks the entire retained chain, uses readable field names, reports Item 13 by reference section, and preserves the complete previous and revised text. **Export PDF change report** creates a paginated static record and writes the export to the audit history. If an earlier parent was deleted, the report identifies the missing record and starts with the earliest retained revision.

Item 3 follows the DD Form 254 Instructions when you spawn:

Spawned	Item 3
Original, from a Solicitation	3a is marked and its date is empty. Enter the award’s release or signature date; it may differ from the solicitation’s.
Revision, from an Original or a Revision	3b is marked. 3a keeps the Original’s date. The revision number is the next one for that Original: one more than the highest held by any of its Revisions that is not cancelled, so two Revisions never share a number. Enter the revision date.
Final, from an Original or a Revision	3c is marked. 3a keeps the Original’s date. Enter the final date and complete Item 5.

On a Revision or Final, Item 3a is required and must match the Original’s date; a different date is a blocking error, because the original date does not change. The revision number is required and must be a whole number (1, 2, 3). Both the official PDF and the flattened PDF print the original date in 3a alongside the revision or final date, with only one box marked. Revision numbers restart at 1 for an award, whose Original has its own date.

A spawned child inherits the form content and the ongoing work — to-dos and notes. It does not inherit anything that happened to the parent: holds, distribution records, countersignature, issue date, review date, permission to bypass validation, or NISS verification.

NISS verification is a check for one issuance. An Original spawned from a solicitation, a Revision or a Final is a new issuance, often months later, so it starts unverified. If the parent was verified, the new card shows **NISS re-confirm**; hovering shows when and by whom the parent was verified. Verifying again clears it and the audit log records the re-confirmation. **Copy** is unchanged — see 3.4.

3.4 Copying a DD-254

Copy asks which kind you want, because copying means two different things. Neither kind carries the original's workflow.

Choice	What comes across
Copy	The whole dashboard face — title, contract, contractor, notes, to-dos, NISS verification and the form. Right when the paperwork is correct and this is a fresh run of it.
Copy the form only	The form and the NISS verification. The notes and to-dos stay on the original, because they are the record of work already done on it.

Either way the copy starts at **Draft** with no workflow history: status, holds, distribution record, countersignature, issue date, review date and the validation override stay with the original. Those are things that happened to that DD-254, and a copy they did not happen to must not claim them. Copying uses the same routine a spawned revision uses, so this means the same thing everywhere.

Resetting a DD-254 in place. A card carrying workflow history shows a **Reset workflow** button, so a DD-254 you have worked on can be put back to a clean run without copying it and losing everything done since. It is the same reset a copy performs, with a confirmation listing exactly what will go.

1. Kept: the form, your notes, to-dos and NISS verification.
2. Cleared: status, holds, distribution records, countersignature, issue date, review date and the Draft override.

A record that states something already happened — **Issued**, **Cancelled**, **Skipped** — cannot be reset. Clearing the distribution record off a DD-254 that went out the door does not make it unissued; it only makes the tool lie about it. Copy it instead — the copy starts clean.

Resetting is not a way past an approval hold. Any Item 10, 11 or 14 box still ticked raises its hold again immediately and the card returns to Blocked. The reset clears the workflow, not the reasons for it.

3.5 Status is gated by validation

You cannot move a card out of Draft while it has validation errors; the status snaps back. Tick the override checkbox on the card to permit a status regardless of missing fields. Cancelling and skipping are exempt — those are exactly the moments a form is incomplete.

Records that already record something that happened — **Issued**, **Cancelled**, **Skipped** — are left alone by autosave. Opening an old issued DD-254 after a rule change will not quietly demote it to Draft; it went out the door, and the tool does not rewrite that. Setting a status by hand still runs the full gate.

3.6 Holds — recording why something is stuck

Setting a card to Blocked requires a reason. The status will not change until you type one, and cancelling returns the card to its previous status. If reasons are optional in Settings (2.5), you can save without one; the hold then reads **No reason given**.

The reason is stored as a hold and appears in a red panel on the card face, visible without opening anything. Each hold records the status that raised it and the date. Tick a hold to resolve it; the badge flips from a red open-hold count to a green **holds cleared**. You can add further holds from the panel without touching the status.

Issuing with an open hold is possible but challenged — you are shown the outstanding holds and must confirm, and the override is written to the audit log.

3.7 Approval holds — the stop that makes you think

Some boxes on a DD-254 cannot be flowed to a contractor on your say-so alone; somebody outside this tool has to approve them. When you tick one, the tool raises an **approval hold** and moves the card to Blocked.

This is not the tool refusing to issue. It is a deliberate stop that makes you ask the questions worth asking: do we hold this authority, how did we get it, and what permits us to release this part of the DD-254 to a subcontractor. Sometimes the answer is that you already hold standing authority. That is a perfectly good answer — it just has to be written down.

Box	What it is	Who approves
10a	COMSEC information	GCA
10c	CNWDI	GCA
10e(1)	Sensitive Compartmented Information	Senior Intelligence Officer
10e(2)	Non-SCI intelligence information	GCA
10f	Special Access Program information	Program Security Officer
10g	NATO information	GCA
10h	Foreign Government Information	GCA
11i	TEMPEST requirements	GCA, on a CTTA determination
11j	OPSEC requirements	GCA
11k	Defense Courier Service	GCA
Item 14	Additional security requirements	GCA

3. The hold reads, for example: *Item 10a COMSEC information checked — GCA approval required before issue. Record approving authority, date and reference.*
4. While any approval hold is open the DD-254 **cannot reach Ready to sign or Issued**. Attempting it returns the card to Blocked and lists what is outstanding.
5. The validation override checkbox does **not** clear an approval hold. An override that could wave away an approval gate would defeat the only thing the gate is for.
6. Clearing one asks how. Four common answers are offered as one-click starting points — standing authority you already hold, a GCA response, approval carried by the prime DD-254, or not required and why — and each fills a text box you complete. A one-word clearance is refused.

7. Un-ticking the box does not delete the hold. It is marked **superseded**, so the record still shows the box was once checked and why it stopped applying.

> Ticking 11i or 11j automatically sets Item 14 to YES, so those raise two holds rather than one. That is correct: both need answering.

Every raise, clearance and supersession goes to the audit log, so the Notes Report and the audit CSV together show what was approved, by whom, and on what basis.

3.8 Cancelling and skipping

Cancelled is available at any stage and demands a reason, unless reasons are optional in Settings (2.5). The reason, the date, and the status it was cancelled from are recorded and shown on the card. Cancelled work drops out of the working list; click the Cancelled chip to see it. A chain only disappears when the whole chain is cancelled — cancelling a solicitation does not hide a live Original spawned from it.

Skipped appears in the dropdown only on Solicitation cards. Use it when the customer dropped the solicitation and later came straight to an Original. Spawning never sets it for you; you mark the solicitation Skipped or Issued yourself.

3.9 Notes and to-do items

Click **Notes** on a card to expand its panel. **Notes** is free text and appears in the Notes Report and the Manager Rollup. **To-do** items are the running “I need…” list; each requires a note-taken date, and any item can be turned into an Outlook calendar reminder dated to that note.

3.10 Finding things

Type what you have in hand, in any order — typically the requestor, then the subcontractor CAGE, then the prime number. Every word you type must appear in the same DD-254, but the order does not matter, so **pat.requestor 5XYZ5 W911NF** and **W911NF 5XYZ5 pat.requestor** find the same record. Put words in quotes to match them as an exact phrase. A contract number of four or more characters matches with or without punctuation: **W911NF26C0001** finds **W911NF-26-C-0001**.

The search box matches far more than the title: contract number, contractor, CAGE, GCA, every text field on the form including Block 13, note text, hold and cancellation text, and both the number and the name of every checked Item 10 and 11 box. Searching **10a** and searching **COMSEC** return the same contracts. A match on a revision surfaces the whole chain it belongs to. You can also filter by requestor and by status, and sort by recent activity, date created, title or status urgency.

3.11 NISS verification and countersignature

NISS records that you verified the contractor's facility clearance and safeguarding for this DD-254. Click the badge, enter your initials, and the date and initials are stored. A newly spawned Original, Revision or Final shows **NISS re-confirm** instead of **NISS not verified** when its parent had been verified. Issuing without it is possible but challenged. **Countersigned** records the date the signed form came back and asks where that signature is held. DoDM 5205.07 requires the subcontractor's authorised representative to sign but does not say where, and the APR 2018 form has no subcontractor signature block — Item 17 is the issuer's certification and its one signature field, 17h, belongs to the certifying official. Capture the signature however your programme accepts it, and record the location: without a block on the form, that is the only thing identifying it. The badge appears only on a SAP subcontract (the SAP flag with a subcontractor in Item 2b or 7a), on every issuance of it; the DD Form 254 instructions ask for no subcontractor signature on other forms. A signature recorded on any other card stays in its record and the portfolio export.

3.12 What a card tells you at a glance

Beside the stage chip, every card carries an **UNCLASSIFIED** or purple **CUI** handling badge. That badge reports how *this form* is marked, and it comes from the marking selector or the marking carried by the template the draft was built from. Item 10j, Item 11l, CUI designation fields, a distribution statement and LDCs say the *contract* involves CUI, which is a different fact: a DD Form 254 naming CUI categories for a classified contract is routinely UNCLASSIFIED, and marking it CUI would be a marking error in its own right. When the contract involves CUI, validation says so and points at the Item 13 protection guidance the GCA must supply; it does not change the marking, the encryption banner, the bulk-issuance audience or the e-mail subject line.

A card also carries a **paperclip badge** counting everything that must travel with that DD-254: what its own selections require, what the template it was built from demands, and anything you recorded by hand. Click the badge to open the card on the full list, grouped by where each item came from. A form with nothing to attach shows no badge. The count is computed from the same source the distribution dialog uses, so the two can never disagree.

3.13 Distribution

Who the e-mail goes to. The **To** line is everyone the DD-254 has to reach, and none of it is optional: the requestor, the **Item 7** FSO of the receiving facility, every **Item 8** performance-location FSO, the **cognizant security office**, and anyone written into **Block 18f**. The **CC** line carries the addresses you entered on this form yourself — the hand-typed FSO list, and managers added with **Add to CC** — plus the **Security Manager** or the **Item 6 FSO** if your office has ticked them under **Manage** → **Settings** (2.5). Those two start off. An address needed twice appears once, on To.

> A DD-254 cannot be flagged **Issued** while one of those required recipients applies to it and has no address recorded. The message names each one — a performance site by its location rather than as “an Item 8 FSO” — so you know which field to fill. This is a stop, not a question: the other issuance prompts ask you to weigh something, and this one reports an address nobody has written down yet. **Applies** is the safeguard: an Item 7 that names no subcontractor is not a gap, so a prime DD-254 is issued exactly as before. Bulk issuance uses the same rule, and refuses the whole selection rather than issuing part of it.

Flagging a DD-254 **Issued** opens a distribution dialog built from that form's own Item 18 — each checked box becomes a row, checked 18f pulls in its address text, and the requestor gets its own separate row. Unchecking 18f clears its hidden text, and legacy text stored behind an unchecked 18f is ignored everywhere. Addresses are prefilled strictly from their own source: **18a from the Item 6 contractor FSO e-mail and nothing else**, 18b from the Item 7 subcontractor FSO, 18c from the 6c, 7c and 8c security office text. Every box is free text with a picker holding every address the form knows, so you can correct anything.

> If Item 6 carries no FSO e-mail, **18a is left blank** rather than guessed at. A blank row makes you look; a wrongly prefilled one invites a send. Drafts created before the Item 6 and 7 FSO e-mail fields existed will therefore show a blank 18a — their old addresses are still one click away in the row’s picker.

The same dialog offers **Open e-mail**. It is the direct browser e-mail link the user clicks — there is no scripted web-window popup. Windows hands it to Outlook when Outlook is the computer's registered mail handler, or to the computer's other default mail application. **To** contains the requestor, Item 7 subcontractor FSO and every Item 8 performance-location FSO. **CC** contains the Item 6 facility FSO, security and program security managers, additional manual FSOs, Item 6/7/8 CSO addresses and checked Item 18f addresses. Duplicate addresses are removed case-insensitively across both lines, so a person on To is not repeated on CC. Each populated address is separated from the next with a **semicolon followed by one space** so the mail application receives distinct recipients. Item 13 prose is not automatically added to this prepared message. A CUI document marking makes the subject begin

exactly **(CUI)(CUI)(CUI)** as a visual warning. If the recipient link is too long for a reliable browser handoff, Open e-mail is disabled and the dialog offers **Copy To** and **Copy CC** instead.

> If **Open e-mail** opens a browser instead of Outlook, do not clear every Windows default. First press **Windows key + R**, enter **mailto:test@example.com?subject=DD254%20test**, and press Enter. If that test opens a browser, go to **Settings > Apps > Default apps > Outlook (classic)**, set the **MAILTO** link type to Outlook, and set **.eml** to Outlook as well. Repeat the Windows key + R test before returning to the tool. If the test already opens Outlook but an embedded viewer does not, open the DD-254 tool directly from File Explorer in a regular browser.

> Opening the e-mail does not send it and does not record distribution. Review and send it in the mail application, then use **Record distribution** separately so the audit history reflects what actually happened.

Everything defaults to ticked; untick what has not gone yet and log it later.

Button	What happens
Open e-mail	Opens a prepared message in the computer's default e-mail application. Nothing is sent or recorded automatically.
Record distribution	The ticked rows are logged and the DD-254 is issued.
Skip for now	The DD-254 is *still issued*; **issued-without-distribution** goes to the audit log and you log the recipients later from the card.
Cancel the issuance	The DD-254 is **not** issued. The status goes back where it was, no issue date is set and nothing is recorded, with **issue-cancelled** written to the audit log.

> Pressing Escape cancels the issuance rather than skipping. Dismissing a dialog should never be the action that puts a DD-254 out the door.

8. Cancelling a re-issue leaves the original issue date alone — only a date this transition would have set is cleared.

The dialog also lists **Attach before you send** — the documents your selections require, anything the language template demands, and your own free-text notes — with a copy button. If the DD Form 254 is marked CUI it carries a **SEND ENCRYPTED** banner citing DoDI 5200.48.

On the card, the **distributed** badge is a button: click it to expand straight to the distribution log, where each row shows the timestamp, party, recipient and method.

Bulk issuance

Tick two or more card checkboxes. The selection bar offers **Issue selected**; changing any selected card's status to **Issued** starts the same group action. The tool preflights every selected DD-254 before changing any of them.

> Bulk issuance is all or nothing. A record that is already Issued, Cancelled or Skipped, a validation error without that record's own override, or any open approval hold stops the whole group before the distribution window. Open operational holds and missing NISS verification are shown once for the group and still require an explicit decision.

The bulk window shows one section per DD-254, with that record's own Item 18 parties and attachment list. It creates a separate prepared e-mail whenever selected records do not have exactly the same To line, CC line and CUI handling. Each audience panel names the DD-254s that belong in it; never attach a record to a different panel's message. Within a group, requestors, Item 7 subcontractor FSOs and Item 8 performance-location FSOs are on To. Facility FSOs, security/program security managers, CSOs, additional manual FSOs and checked Item 18f

addresses are on CC. Addresses are deduplicated case-insensitively and separated with semicolon-space. A CUI and non-CUI record never share a message, even when their addresses match.

Button	What happens
Open e-mail N	Opens the prepared message for that exact audience group. Nothing is sent or recorded automatically.
Issue all and record distribution	Issues every selected DD-254 and stores only its own ticked distribution rows on that record.
Issue all · log later	Issues every selected DD-254 without a distribution entry; each record's audit history says distribution is still unrecorded.
Cancel all	Leaves every selected DD-254 at its prior status with no issue date or distribution change.

Selected status changes are written in one browser-database transaction, so a storage failure cannot leave only part of the group issued. Each DD-254 still receives its own status, distribution and audit entries. A Revision's biennial review date is recalculated during bulk issuance; create any calendar reminder separately.

3.14 Review dates

The DD Form 254 Instructions, Item 3b(3), call for a review of classification requirements at least biennially, in the context of revisions. That is the clock the dashboard keeps. When you issue a Revision (Item 3b) the tool offers to set the review date two years from the revision date and can produce a calendar invite. The card badges the date, amber near due and red once overdue. The clock applies to revisions only.

Do not confuse it with the Government Contracting Activity's own review. DoD policy requires the GCA to review the security classification requirements of a DD Form 254 at least biennially during contract performance (DoDM 5220.32 Volume 1, paragraph 6.3.g; the requirement was previously in DoDI 5220.22, which DoDI 5220.31 cancelled). That is a government duty. Contractors are bound by 32 CFR Part 117 and the DD Form 254 instructions, not by those DoD issuances.

Performance end and the Final

At the completion of a classified contract, USG-provided and deliverable information goes back to the Government. Unless the GCA advises otherwise, copies may be kept for two years after completion, and the DD Form 254 stays in effect for that period. Keeping them longer needs GCA authorisation and a Final DD Form 254 with disposition instructions; for a subcontract, the subcontractor asks through the prime and the prime issues the Final (32 CFR 117.13(d)(5), 117.15(j) and 117.17(c)). The decision is easy to leave too late, so the card can prompt for it.

- Open a card and enter **Performance ends**. It is a tool-only date: the DD Form 254 has no end date, so it is kept on the dashboard record and never reaches the form, the PDF, Compare or the revision summary.
- The newest Original or Revision of a contract shows **performance ends** with the date. From 120 days out it turns amber and says a retention decision is due, bolder at 60 days and red at 30.
- After the end date the badge counts down to the close of the two-year retention window the same way, saying a Final is needed to keep copies longer. Once the window has closed it stays red.
- Issuing a Final anywhere in the contract's chain clears the prompt. Solicitations, Finals, cancelled and skipped records and superseded cards never show it.

- **Invite** downloads a calendar file with both dates and reminders at 120, 60 and 30 days. Setting, changing and clearing the date are written to the audit log, and the portfolio export has a Performance End column.

> Exercising an option year that extends performance is not a reason to revise the DD Form 254 (Instructions, Item 3b(2)). Change the date on the card; the tool does not suggest a revision.

3.15 Recount validation

The error and warning counts on each card are a snapshot written when a draft is saved, not recomputed as you look at the dashboard. Whenever the validation rules change, every stored draft keeps showing numbers derived from the old rules until you open it.

After an update this happens on its own. Each draft's counts record the tool version that produced them. When the tool loads and finds drafts counted under a different version, it recounts those drafts once, without asking, and writes one entry to the audit log. Status, holds, notes and the form itself are not changed. A draft you try to open waits until the recount finishes. A recount that changes nothing does not count toward your backup reminder.

Manage, then **Recount validation (all drafts)** does the same for every draft on demand and puts back whatever you had open. Nothing else about the drafts is touched. A status change or hold you make on the dashboard while a recount runs is kept. If one draft cannot be checked, the rest still are, and the result says how many were skipped.

> A backup restored during a session is recounted the next time the tool loads, not immediately.

3.16 Drafts saved by an earlier version

v1.14.0 removed the Source & Validation Log and the Optional supporting records. A draft saved by an earlier version can still hold log entries, attached files or supporting records. Opening a draft saves it, and saving drops that material from this browser.

So when you open such a draft, the tool lists what it holds and asks first:

Choice	What happens
Export, then open	Downloads the draft's stored workspace as a JSON file — including any attached file bytes — then asks whether the file finished saving. OK opens the draft; Cancel leaves it unopened and unchanged. The file opens with **Load Draft** in v1.13.0.
Open without exporting	Opens the draft. The material is dropped at the first save.
Cancel	Nothing happens. Escape does the same.

Either way of opening is written to the audit log with a list of what the draft held. An empty log or an untouched records panel, which every draft from v1.11.0 to v1.13.0 carries, raises nothing. A read-only tab does not ask, because it never saves.

> The exported file carries everything the draft held, including attachments. Handle it the way you would handle the draft itself.

3.17 Choosing a contract type or a DD-254 template on a card

Each card carries two pickers. The first applies a **contract type**; the second applies a saved **DD-254 template**. Both are search boxes: type part of a contract number, an order number or a template name and the list narrows as you type, because a library of several hundred cannot be scrolled.

9. The template picker lists **task orders under their own number**. An order that follows its prime resolves to the prime's template, so you never have to remember which prime covers which order.
10. Choosing fills Items 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16 and 18 from what you picked. If Item 13 already has text you are asked before it is replaced.
11. A name that matches nothing applies nothing and says so, rather than guessing at the nearest entry.

> An **Issued**, **Cancelled** or **Skipped** DD-254 is not rewritten — it is the record of what went out. Copy it and apply the template to the copy.

3.18 Creating a DD-254

A DD-254 is named for the person it is for and the contract it is on, so the same contract cannot arrive under three different names. **New Solicitation** and **Original** ask four questions.

Asked	Where it goes
First and last name	Into the name, and kept on the record as the requestor's name.
Prime contract number	Into the name, and into **Item 2a**.
Subcontract number (optional)	After the contract number in the name, and into **Item 2b**.
E-mail	The **requestor e-mail**, which is copied when the DD-254 is distributed.

12. The name builds itself as you type — *Jane Doe — N00178-24-D-1234 · SUB-0001* — and the box holding it is editable, so a DD-254 that does not fit the convention can still be called what it needs to be called.
13. Name, prime contract number and e-mail are required; the e-mail is checked for shape. The subcontract number is optional.
14. A solicitation still has **— Solicitation** added to the end.
15. The **pencil**, on the card and beside the title on the form, reopens the same four fields and rebuilds the name from them.

> An **Issued**, **Cancelled** or **Skipped** DD-254 can be renamed — a name is not a statement about what went out — but Items 2a and 2b are shown without being editable, because those are the record.

16. An **Original** also asks for **Block 2b**. It cannot be left blank: enter the subcontract number, or **N/A** when the DD-254 is not a subcontract. **N/A** goes in Item 2b but is not used in the name.
17. A **Solicitation** also asks for **Block 2c** and the **due date** beside it. Both are required.
18. An optional **task order, BPA, call or effort number** is carried into the task-order field and shown as the DD-254's primary identifier, with the prime contract beside it.
19. If what you type matches exactly one saved template, it is named in the dialog and applied in full when the DD-254 is created. What you typed is not replaced by what the template carries.
20. The **Security Manager** chosen here is kept on this DD-254. Changing the repository later does not change it.

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4. The form — preparing the DD-254

The form is an eight-step wizard with a live validation panel down the right-hand side. Steps are not locked: use Next and Previous, or the step dots, to move freely.

Wizard step	Items covered
Step 1	1a, 1b, 2, 3, 4, 5 — levels, contract numbers, form type
Step 2	6, 7, 8 — contractor, subcontractor, performance locations
Step 3	9 — unclassified description
Step 4	10 — access requirements (12 boxes)
Step 5	11 — performance requirements (13 boxes)
Step 6	12, 13, 14, 15 — public release, security guidance, additional requirements, inspections
Step 7	16, 17 — GCA and certification
Step 8	18 — required distribution

4.1 Two ways to work the form

The form opens as a guided walk — eight steps, one at a time. The button at the top right of the progress bar switches to **one page**, where every section is on a single scrolling page. The choice is remembered between sessions, and switching back lands you on the step you were on.

Step by step is right the first few times. Once you know the form, paging through eight cards to change one field is friction; use one page. Both views are the same form — nothing is hidden in either.

The numbered dots carry a live badge: a red count where that section has outstanding errors, a green tick once a section you have passed is clean. They read the same error list the right-hand panel uses, so a step you have not opened yet still tells you it needs attention.

4.2 The instruction panels

Every item has a collapsible **Instructions** panel carrying the conditional rules for that item, colour-coded REQUIRED, RECOMMENDED and DO NOT. They open automatically the first time you visit a step. Read them; they carry rules this manual only summarises.

Rule-backed red and amber alerts beneath the form items show an **Authority:** footer naming the DD Form 254 instruction or governing source used for the rule. An organisation-specific safeguard that is not a regulatory mandate is labelled **Workflow control:** instead. The footer explains the finding; it does not change its severity or validation effect.

4.3 The right-hand validation panel

Section	What it shows
Errors	Blocking problems. The form cannot leave Draft while any exist.
Item 3 rules	Rules specific to Original, Revised or Final.
Recommendations	Non-blocking warnings and reminders.
Flow-down obligations	What a prime may and may not impose on a subcontractor.
Applicable clauses	FAR and DFARS clauses triggered by your selections.
Item 13 needed	Which selections require language in Block 13.

Section	What it shows
E-mail distribution	Addresses harvested from the form — see 4.11.
Attachment reminder	Documents that must travel with the form.
Completion status	Error and warning counts, and rough progress.

4.4 Which fields the tool insists on

The form marks required fields with a red asterisk. A field that is required *and* empty is also shaded red on the form itself, so you can find it without reading the error list. The shading clears the moment you fill it in.

The tool only enforces the fields **you** are responsible for as the preparer. It does not enforce Item 16 or Item 17.

Field	When it is required
1a, 1b	Always — clearance and safeguarding levels.
2a	When a subcontract number is entered in 2b.
Item 3 date	Always. Which date depends on the form type: 3a original, 3b revision, 3c final.
Item 4	Only when you mark this a follow-on contract.
Item 5	Only when retention is claimed — then both the request date and the authorised period.
6a, 6b, 6c	Always — contractor name and address, CAGE, cognizant security office.
7 FSO e-mail	Once a subcontractor exists. The DD-254 has to reach them.
Item 9	Always — the unclassified description.
Item 12 Q1	Always — DIRECT or THROUGH. If THROUGH, the routing office must be named.
Items 14, 15	When marked YES, the narrative that the YES promises.
10k, 11m	When “Other” is checked, the specify field.

Items 16 and 17 are deliberately not enforced. The GCA block and the certification block are completed by the Government Contracting Activity and the certifying official after you hand the form over. Blocking your draft on somebody else’s fields would stop the tool doing its job. Because the browser does not require these fields, it does not show red required-field asterisks on them. A blank Item 16 or 17 never raises an error or shades red.

1. Complete Items 17h Signature and 17i Date Signed in the generated PDF; they do not appear in the browser.

Errors matter beyond the panel. A form with errors cannot leave Draft, and the exported PDF is stamped DRAFT. Clearing the error list is what makes a form issuable.

4.5 Step 1 — Items 1 to 5

Item 1a — FCL level required

Confidential, Secret or Top Secret. Verify it in NISS or NCAISS before you rely on it — a CAGE code is not evidence of a cleared facility. Do not cite special categories here; Restricted Data, COMSEC, SCI and SAP belong in Item 10.

Item 1b — Safeguarding level at the contractor facility

None, N/A, Confidential, Secret or Top Secret.

- It may never be higher than Item 1a. The tool blocks this outright.
- If Item 11a is checked — access only at another facility — it must be None or N/A.
- If 11b, 11c or 11d is checked it must carry a classification level, not None.

Item 2 — This specification is for

2a prime contract number, 2b subcontract number, 2c solicitation or other number with a due date. Mark one primary type, but 2a and 2b may both carry entries on a subcontract form. Entering anything in 2b makes 2a mandatory.

A separate DD Form 254 is required for every subcontract at every tier. Where services span multiple contracts, enter **Multiple Contracts** rather than a number; other contract-related numbers belong in Item 13.

Item 3 — This specification is

Original (3a), Revised (3b) or Final (3c), each with its own date; a revision also carries a revision number. Do not revise solely to exercise an option year or to update POC information in 16d, 16f, 17a or 17g.

For ordinary completion, 32 CFR 117.13(d)(5) distinguishes returning USG-provided or deliverable information from conditional retention of copies. Beyond two years, continued need requires a final specification or equivalent with disposition instructions. SAP retention needs specific written GCA authorization; continued SAP security requirements follow DoDM 5205.07 section 10.5. A SAP Final therefore does not mechanically require Item 5 Yes solely because Final is selected. Complete Item 5 for retention and record applicable disposition or program direction.

Items 4 and 5 — Follow-on and Final

Item 4 identifies a preceding contract. Item 5, when YES, requires the contractor's formal request date, the GCA-authorised retention period, and final disposition instructions in Item 13. The tool checks Item 13 for disposition language and clears the error once it finds it — the built-in Item 5 template satisfies it.

4.6 Step 2 — Items 6, 7 and 8

Item 6 — Contractor

6a name and address, 6b CAGE, 6c cognizant security office, plus an optional **contractor FSO e-mail**. Fill the block from the Facility template library by typing a CAGE code into the filter above 6a. A SAM.gov lookup sits beside the CAGE field.

Item 7 — Subcontractor

7a name and address, 7b CAGE, 7c CSO, a **required subcontractor FSO e-mail**, and an optional **classified mailing address**. The e-mail is a blocking error once a subcontractor exists — the form has to reach them. Address format is deliberately not policed, so group aliases and multiple addresses are accepted.

Item 8 — Actual performance locations

Use **+ Add Performance Location** for multiple sites. Each carries the location, CAGE, CSO, an optional FSO e-mail and an optional classified mailing address. Listing a location limits all classified performance to the locations listed, so list every one.

- If Item 11a is checked, Item 8a is required.
- If classified work happens at the Item 6a address, enter **See Item 6a** rather than repeating it.
- If inspections will be by anyone other than the DCSA CSO, complete Item 15.

The FSO e-mail and classified mailing address fields are workflow only. They never print on the DD Form 254. The e-mails feed the FSO send list and the distribution record; the mailing addresses are written into Item 13 — see 4.10.

Applying a saved facility or location

When you fill Item 7 or an Item 8 location from a template, a red **CONFIRM** banner appears directly beneath the address. Saved details go stale: verify the address, the CAGE and the FSO name and e-mail against NISS before issuing. Typing by hand never raises it, and it clears when the form is cleared.

4.7 Step 3 — Item 9

A DD-254 created as a **Solicitation** opens Item 9 with *****FOR SOLICITATION PURPOSES ONLY***** on its own line, so a reader meets that before the description. Type the description beneath it.

2. Spawning an Original from that solicitation removes the marker — an award is not for solicitation purposes only. Your description is kept.
3. The marker does not count as a description. A solicitation carrying only the marker still reports Item 9 as empty.

A plain-language unclassified description. Never use classified project names, code words, or descriptions that are themselves classified.

4.8 Step 4 — Item 10, access requirements

Twelve boxes: 10a COMSEC, 10b Restricted Data, 10c CNWDI, 10d FRD, 10e(1) SCI, 10e(2) non-SCI intelligence, 10f SAP, 10g NATO, 10h FGI, 10i ACCM, 10j CUI, 10k Other. The interactions the tool enforces:

- 10c CNWDI requires 10b Restricted Data.
- 10f SAP forces Item 14 to YES and requires Item 15.
- 10e(1) SCI requires Item 15 to name the Senior Intelligence Officer.
- 10k Other requires the specify field.
- 10a COMSEC with accountable material stored at the contractor also needs 11h. Accessed only at a government facility, it does not.
- 10j CUI applies only when a classified contract also carries CUI requirements.

Access Eligibility Advisor

The advisor beneath Item 10 compares Items 1a, 1b, 10 and 11 with a verification snapshot. It looks for potential contradictions involving SCI, SAP, NATO, CNWDI, RD/FRD, COMSEC, FGI, ACCM, CUI, foreign or NATO recipients, SAPF or SCIF status, and the Item 11l classified-access basis.

Every finding shows the authority or guidance used for the comparison. The source set includes 32 CFR Part 117, the DD Form 254 Instructions, DoDM 5105.21 Volume 3, DoDM 5205.07, DoDI 5200.48 and DoDM 5200.01 Volume 3.

The advisor is informational only. It never enters Live Validation, adds an error or warning, changes status, blocks issuance, or changes the exported DD Form 254. Verify actual eligibility and safeguarding in NISS and retain the supporting record.

4.9 Step 5 — Item 11, performance requirements

Thirteen boxes. The mutually exclusive combinations are enforced as hard errors:

- 11a — access only at another facility — excludes 11b, 11c, 11d, 11h, 11i and 11k.

- 11b — receive and store documents only — excludes 11a, 11c, 11d, 11h, 11i and 11k.
- 11c and 11d each exclude 11a and 11b.

11e services only is not recommended alongside 11b, 11c or 11d; use 11m instead, and explain in Item 13 if you keep both. Other consequences: 11f overseas requires Item 13 detail and forces Item 18d; 11g requires DD Form 1540; 11i TEMPEST and 11j OPSEC each force Item 14 to YES; 11l is expected only alongside 10j.

A prime may not impose TEMPEST, OPSEC or Defense Courier use on a subcontractor without prior GCA written approval. The Flow-down panel lists every selection carrying this constraint, and where a prime DD-254 is compared with a subcontract DD-254, a clearance or safeguarding level above the prime's is a blocking error. An Original, Revision or Final spawned on the dashboard is an issuance of the same contract, not a subcontract, so it is never compared with its parent this way: raising a level or adding a box is what a revision is for.

Item 11 Performance Advisor

The advisor beneath Item 11 cross-checks each selected 11a through 11m block against Items 1b, 10, 13, 14 and 18. Questions shown for the selected blocks capture the evidence behind the choice, including access locations, classification guidance, storage, overseas coordination, DTIC sponsorship, COMSEC account authority, TEMPEST or OPSEC direction, Defense Courier approval, CUI designation and other written authority.

These questions and findings are part of the draft's verification record but are excluded from official PDF data. Like the Access Eligibility Advisor, they never create validation errors, change status or block issuance.

4.10 Step 6 — Items 12 to 15

Item 12 — Public release

Q1 is the release routing, DIRECT or THROUGH — marking it is expected and the tool reminds you. Q2 is the release authority: office name, phone and e-mail where available. Q2 is optional and leaving it blank raises nothing.

Item 13 — Security guidance

The substance of the form. The editor accepts bold and underline for on-screen readability; the exported form is always plain text. Buttons above the field insert standard paragraphs, laid out as a heading and a blank line:

```
Reference 10a:

Access to classified COMSEC information requires…
```

Write in plain language, be specific, and name the item you are expanding on. Every document cited here must reach the contractor. Do not copy NISPOM text in verbatim, and avoid citing internal GCA directives — extract the relevant portions as attachments.

The tool scans Block 13 for references and compares them against your selections. A reference to a box you have not checked is a blocking error, wherever it appears in the text — **10a**, **10A:**, **Ref 10a** and **Reference 10A** all register. Genuine cross-references stay inert: **See Item 10a for guidance** and **Ref. 10a: N/A** raise nothing.

Items 14 and 15

Item 14 covers requirements over and above NISPOM — YES is required for 10f, 11i and 11j, and may be required for 11f. Item 15 covers inspections, and is required for SAP, for SCI (naming the Senior Intelligence Officer), and whenever inspections are by anyone other than the DCSA CSO.

4.11 Steps 7 and 8 — Items 16, 17 and 18

Item 16 is the GCA block, 16a to 16f. The browser captures Items 17a, 17b, 17c, 17e, 17f and 17g from Certifier templates; 17d AAC is not held in a template and 17e is for subcontracts only. Complete 17h Signature and 17i Date Signed in the generated dynamic PDF.

4. Neither block is enforced by the validation panel — see 4.3. You can complete and issue a form with both left empty.

Item 18 is the required distribution: 18a contractor FSO, 18b subcontractor FSO, 18c cognizant security office, 18d overseas activity, 18e ACO, 18f other with a free-text field. 18d must be checked whenever 11f is checked, and 18b on any subcontract form. What you tick here becomes the checklist presented when you record distribution.

4.12 Classified mailing addresses

If the subcontractor or a performance location holds a separate classified mailing address, put it in that block's optional field. The tool maintains a matching section at the bottom of Item 13:

```
Classified Mailing Address (Beta Corp):
PO Box 0000
Anytown, ST 00000
```

Each entry is labelled with whose it is. Edit an address and the block rewrites in place; clear one and only that entry goes; clear them all and the block disappears. Text you have written above it is never touched.

4.13 The e-mail distribution panel

Three groups. **1 — CSO and requestor** collects addresses from the 6c, 7c and 8c security office text plus the requestor field. **2 — FSOs** lists the contractor, subcontractor and location FSO e-mails automatically, with a manual box beneath for anyone not covered by Items 6, 7 or 8. **3 — per DD-254 requirement** picks up addresses in Item 13 and Block 18f.

Each address is listed once, under the first group it belongs to. If the FSO group shows **already listed above**, the address is recorded as a CSO or requestor contact rather than missing.

4.14 Item 13 has three managed regions

Item 13 is still one block of text you can type into freely, but three regions of it are written and rewritten by the tool. They keep the order below, and each is rewritten in place rather than appended, so editing a value never stacks a second copy.

Region	Where it comes from	Where it sits
Supported effort line	The effort number under Item 2	The very top
Your text and inserted language	You, and the template libraries	The middle
Classified mailing addresses	Item 7 and each performance location	Below your text
CUI designation block	The fields under Item 18	The tail, after five blank rows

The supported effort line. A field under Item 2 takes a number. Entering one writes a line at the top of Item 13; changing it rewrites that line; clearing it removes the line and leaves the rest intact. If you move the line down the block by hand, it is rewritten where you put it. The number never reaches an official form field.

The CUI designation block. Fields under Item 18 build a labelled block at the foot of Item 13. Filling any one field writes every label, leaving the others blank. Clearing them all removes the block and its blank rows. Rows print in a fixed order, not the order you filled them.

Standard Language and Contract Type templates respect these regions: inserted language lands below the effort line and above the CUI block, and a Contract Type template that replaces Item 13 loses neither.

4.15 Limited dissemination controls and distribution statements

Two pickers feed the CUI designation block.

Limited dissemination controls. Ten controls, each with its marking. Tick any number; they print alphabetised by marking and slash-separated, so the order you tick them cannot change what appears. Three — REL TO, DISPLAY ONLY and DL ONLY — take a list, and the list box appears only while that control is ticked. A list-bearing control with nothing typed yet prints as its bare marking, never a placeholder.

Distribution statements. Six statements, A to F. A and F take no reason for control; the others offer only the reasons their statement permits. Switching statement drops a reason that is no longer valid and keeps one that still is. Statement C assembles around its fill-ins; F takes a controlling office and a date. An unfilled slot leaves no stray separator, and a missing controlling office stays visibly unfilled rather than silently vanishing.

> Neither the dissemination controls nor the distribution statement is written into an official form field. They exist to build the Item 13 designation block.

4.16 Item 13 in sections layout

With **Item 13 layout** set to **Sections** you get one box per ticked Item 10 or 11 entry instead of a single block. Typing in a box writes through to the real Item 13 immediately: there is one store, and the boxes are a view of it. Unticking an Item 10 or 11 box removes its complete managed section from Item 13 even when the section contains language, so stale guidance cannot create a reverse-reference error.

The removed section is kept briefly as an undo record. **Put back** rechecks the item and restores its wording; otherwise the removed language does not print or remain in the draft.

Each section is written as its reference, a blank line, then the text. Sections land in form order regardless of the order you write them, and rewriting one replaces it in place. Prose you typed outside any section is never touched.

The raw Item 13 field stays visible in this layout as a failsafe, and editing it directly is authoritative — the boxes follow. Switching layout never alters the stored text.

In sections layout the Item 10 and 11 template cards move out of the side panel into the section boxes themselves, each offering insert and save. Language for other items stays in the side panel as before.

4.17 Setting a validation flag aside

A finding you have considered and judged not to apply can be set aside. It needs an open draft and a written reason; a dismissal without one is refused unless reasons are optional in Settings (2.5), when it is recorded as **No reason given**. The finding stays visible, struck through, with your reason attached, and stops counting toward the blocking total. Putting it back restores the count.

Every dismissal is written to the audit log with its reason, author and time. If the underlying rule is later reworded, the tool asks for your judgement again rather than carrying the old one forward.

> A dismissal cannot clear a compliance hold. Approval gates are not findings and are not dismissible.

4.18 Two panels, not one

The right-hand column holds two separately scrolling panels: validation output in one, the things you act on in the other. Collapsing hides both.

4.19 Sensitive-terms screen

Item 9 must never carry classified project names, code words or descriptions that are themselves sensitive, and Item 13 is where such names most often slip in. **Manage, then Sensitive terms** keeps a list of words to look for on this browser.

> Enter **unclassified** terms only — for example unclassified program nicknames or customer-sensitive names. Never enter classified information in this tool, and that includes the terms list.

5. Type one term per line, up to five words each, and choose **Add**. Case, spacing and punctuation do not matter: **Kestrel-7** and **kestrel 7** are the same term. Whole words are matched, so **Kestrel-77** does not match **Kestrel-7**.
6. The list is stored in this browser as one-way fingerprints. Nobody, including you, can read it back. It is not in Full Backup, template packs or any export, so re-enter it on another browser. To remove a term, type it again and choose **Remove**; **Clear all** empties the list.
7. When Item 9 or Item 13 contains a listed term, validation shows a warning that says which item, but never the term, because warnings are copied into the Preparer's Worksheet and the dashboard counts. A note directly under the field shows the matched phrase on screen. The note never prints.

> A match is a warning, never an error: it does not block a status or an export. Remove the phrase or confirm it may appear on the form. Recount does not run the screen; it runs when a draft is open.

4.20 Revision summary in Item 13

A revised DD Form 254 is incorporated into the contract by modification, and whoever incorporates it needs to know what changed. When you open a Revision spawned from an Original or an earlier Revision for the first time, the tool writes a summary at the top of Item 13, below the supported-effort line if there is one:

```
Summary of changes in Revision 2 (from Revision 1 dated 20260301):
- Item 1a Facility Clearance Level: changed from Secret to Top Secret.
- Item 11c Receive, store, AND generate classified information or material: added.
```

- Every field that prints is compared with the issuance the Revision was spawned from, unless you choose another with Redraft. Item 3 dates and numbers are not listed. Boxes read **added** or **removed**; short entries show both values; long text such as Item 9 says **revised**; Item 13 changes are named by Reference section.
- While the summary is the tool's own text it is rewritten as you change the form. It waits while the cursor is in Item 13 and catches up when you leave it. The bar above Item 13 says whether it is being kept up to date.
- Edit the summary by hand and the tool leaves it exactly as you wrote it. **Redraft** replaces it with a fresh one after asking. **Remove** takes it out and leaves the rest of Item 13 as it was; the tool does not put it back.
- When there is more than one earlier issuance, **Redraft** asks which to summarize from: the one the Revision was spawned from, the Original, or any Revision in between. The heading names the choice, and it is kept with the draft for later updates. The point-of-contact warning still compares with the issuance the Revision was spawned from, because it is about this revision.
- Spawning the next Revision or a Final drops the previous summary, because a summary describes one revision. A new Revision starts from its own parent.

The DD Form 254 instructions set no format for a revision summary; Item 13 is where anything that might be unclear is explained. Review the wording before issuing. If the only changes are point-of-contact details in Items 16d-16f or 17a-17g, validation warns that the instructions say not to revise for that alone.

---

5. Templates — building them and using them

Nine libraries live under **Templates** on the dashboard. All are local to this browser and all are included in the Full Backup.

Library	Holds	Fills
Facility	Item 6 address, CAGE, FSO e-mail, linked 6c CSO, linked Item 17 certifying official	6a, 6b, 6c, FSO e-mail, 17a-c and 17e-g
CSO	Security office name, address, phone, e-mail	6c, 7c, 8c
Performance / Sub	Location, CAGE, CSO, FSO e-mail, classified mailing address	7a-c, 8a-c and their extras
Certifier	Name, title, address, CAGE, phone, e-mail of the official who certifies the form	17a-c, 17e-g
Contract Type	A whole DD-254 posture, offered when a draft is created	10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 18
DD-254 Template Language	The same, insertable piece by piece from the form	10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 18
Security Managers	Name, e-mail, program	Assigned to a language template
Standard Language	Recurring text your organisation puts on its own DD-254s	13
Security Classification Guides	Unclassified title, identifier, date, issuing office, distribution statement and delivery of each guide	13 (a citation line)

5.1 Working the template tables

1. **Add** appends a blank row. Typing is saving; there is no save button.
2. The up and down arrows reorder the list, which is the order the dropdowns show.
3. The red cross deletes a row. **Undo last change** puts it back — one level, and it covers row deletions as well as spreadsheet uploads.
4. **Done** returns to the dashboard and flushes anything pending.

Give every row a Label; that is what you see in the dropdown. In Facility and Performance / Sub, the CSO dropdown *links* a row to a CSO template rather than copying its text, so correcting the CSO once corrects everything using it. The Facility row carries a second dropdown that links the **certifying official** who signs Item 17 for that facility, the same way: correct the official once in the Certifier library and every facility naming them follows.

Duplicate CAGE codes across rows are flagged as you type. Two rows with the same CAGE usually means one is stale.

5.2 Saving from the form into a template

You do not have to build the tables up front. Fill a form once, then push what you typed into the library.

Where you are	What to click	Where it lands
Item 7 filled in	Save this sub-contractor to Performance/Sub templates	Performance / Sub
An Item 8 location filled in	Save this location to Performance/Sub templates	Performance / Sub
A whole form you want to reuse	Save this language template, at Item 18	DD-254 Template Language

Saving carries the FSO e-mail and the classified mailing address with the entry, and links the CSO automatically when the 8c text still matches a CSO template. Editing that text by hand drops the link rather than asserting something false. Re-saving with a field left blank never wipes what is already stored.

Performance and subcontractor locations are also harvested automatically: every time you leave the form for the dashboard, any location you typed is added if it is not already there. Placeholder text such as **See Item 6a** is ignored.

> Item 6 has no save-to-template button. Build facility entries in the Facility library directly, or import them by spreadsheet.

5.3 Applying a template into a form

- Item 6 — type a CAGE code into the facility filter above 6a. It fills 6a, 6b, the linked 6c, the FSO e-mail and, if the facility names one, the Item 17 certifying official. You do not have to use the filter for Item 17: whenever the CAGE in 6b names a facility that has an official linked, opening the draft or finishing that field fills Item 17, provided Item 17 is completely empty. Anything already in Item 17 is left alone, so the block never ends up holding two people.
- 6c, 7c and 8c — each carries an apply CSO template dropdown above the field.
- Items 7 and 8 — the Performance / Sub search fills location, CAGE, CSO, FSO e-mail and classified mailing address together.
- Item 17 — the certifying-official dropdown above 17a fills 17a, 17b, 17c, 17e, 17f and 17g. 17d AAC is not held in the template. A facility template that names an official fills the same six fields when you apply it at Item 6, so on a form for one of your own facilities you need not touch this dropdown at all.
- A whole posture — the Contract type dropdown on the dashboard card applies a Contract Type template. It ticks Items 10, 11 and 18, sets the Item 12 routing, fills 14, 15 and 16, and writes Block 13. See 5.6.

5.4 Building a DD-254 Template Language entry

A single entry carries language for twelve items at once — what you reach for when a programme has a standard security posture you issue repeatedly.

5. Dashboard, then Manage, then DD-254 Template Language, then **Add template**. Enter the prime contract number, template name and program; choose **Add prime template**. Add an own-order DD254 with **Add task order** beneath that prime.
6. Name it for the posture, and set the **Source date** — the version date of the authority the language came from, not today. Until you set it the entry shows a red NO SOURCE DATE badge everywhere.

7. Assign a **Security / program manager**; it searches the Security Managers library and includes the manager on CC. At Item 18, choose more managers from the dropdown and click **Add to CC**. Remove an additional selection with its cross. The manager assignment and added contacts are kept with the saved draft.
8. **Edit blocks** to set the form's own classification (UNCLASSIFIED or CUI) and fill Items 10 and 11 (each ticked box opens a text area for Block 13 language tied to that box), 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 18, and a free-text list of required attachments.

Every box in Items 10, 11 and 18 is shown with its full name, not just its number — 10j reads *Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI)*. The wording is read from the form itself, so a template can never label a box differently from the DD-254 it will be applied to.

> The classification here is the marking supported by this tool: UNCLASSIFIED or CUI. That is a tool restriction, not a rule that every DD Form 254 must be unclassified. Applying a template sets it on the form and repaints the banner, and the marking then shows on the dashboard card. A spreadsheet row asking for anything higher falls back to UNCLASSIFIED rather than storing a marking the form cannot carry.

Capture from form snapshots the open form instead. It never overwrites your per-checkbox language or the attachment list, because neither exists on the form.

> Capture takes Block 13 as one block of text. If you had previously applied a different template to that form, its language is now in Block 13 and will be captured. Capture from a clean form, or check Block 13 straight afterwards.

On the form, select an entry in the Template language panel to see its content as cards. **Insert all of this template** sits at the top and applies every section in one go — the classification, the Item 10, 11 and 18 boxes, the Item 12 routing, Blocks 13, 14, 15 and 16. It asks before replacing represented sections, including blanks and unchecked boxes. A blank Item 18f clears the previous address. Sections entirely absent from a legacy template remain untouched. Facility information, certification and contract numbers already entered remain separate from language replacement. Beneath it each section still has its own insert or apply button if you want only part of it. Nothing is applied automatically. Per-checkbox language inserts itself into Block 13 as you tick the matching box and removes itself if you untick it. The required attachments appear in the attachment reminder and again in the distribution dialog.

Organising the repository and checking duplicates

Use **Add template** to create a prime-contract DD254 with its Block 2A number, name and program. New primes appear at the top in the default Newest first sort. Every matching prime and order is available by scrolling; there are no repository pages. Use **Program**, **Prime contract**, coverage and order-number filters, or search by name, program, contract number or template wording. Contract-number and program sorts change the view without changing stable template references.

Find duplicates narrows the same editable rows to repeated identities: the same prime number for prime templates, or the same prime plus order number for own-order templates. Case and surrounding spaces are ignored. Names, source dates, revisions and wording do not distinguish an identity. Identical language under different contracts or orders produces no warning. **Compare** shows field differences underneath the row; **Keep both - mark reviewed** records your decision without merging or deleting either template.

> Editing continues to autosave so no work is lost. Save now and Done ask about unreviewed duplicate flags. Imports also report possible duplicates. No template is automatically merged or deleted. Saving a new template directly from Item 18 warns before adding a matching copy; cancelling adds nothing.

Saving from Item 18 captures the prime contract, order number, order type and the outgoing order-specific selection with the current language. Capture from form on an existing repository row preserves its contract/order metadata and required attachment list.

Orders under a prime and their received source

9. Choose **Add task order** beneath the prime. Its Block 2A number is inherited. Enter the order number, choose Task Order, BPA or Delivery Order, and select prime or own DD254 coverage. The same order number under the same prime is refused even if case differs. That number under another prime is a separate order. The child program initially follows the parent and can be edited.
10. Choose **Use prime DD254** for a compact Follows prime DD254 entry. No copied language template is created. Choose **Use task-order-specific DD254** to create an independent blank DD254 template, editable beneath the prime with the same source metadata, manager, block selections, wording and attachment requirements. Its own requirements must be entered or captured from the form.
11. Use **Edit blocks** to open the complete editor for either a prime or own template. Fill the received DD254 source type, date and language. Editing an own template saves only that template. The child prime number is inherited; changing its order number updates its order record. Saved orders show their coverage as a label. The prime/own choice is available only in Add task order, so editing a saved template cannot switch its coverage.
12. A changed, moved or removed template, or a newer source date, raises **Review DD254**. Select the required current template within the order's existing prime or own coverage before creating a new workflow. When several revisions match, choose one explicitly. Review cannot switch the coverage type. Saved source history is available with readable DD254 item names in the review panel. Existing workflows retain the version from which they started.
13. **Create DD254** creates a new Original using the selected received source; **Open DD254** opens an existing linked workflow. The parent prime stays in Item 2a and the order appears in the effort field and Item 13 support line. The incoming source choice does not choose the outgoing order-specific checkbox; select that separately if appropriate. Complete and validate the rest of the form as usual.

> Full Backup includes orders and their shared saved source versions. DD254-language JSON export carries these records too. Template packs label the order library separately and default it off on import. CSV carries source templates only; use JSON or Full Backup to move order links and history. Duplicate detection does not flag twenty legitimate orders using the same source.

Importing a received DD Form 254

When a customer or higher-tier contractor sends you a DD Form 254, its wording is usually the starting point for the subcontract DD-254 you issue. Instead of retyping it, open **Templates**, then **DD-254 Template Language**, and choose **Import received DD 254 (PDF)**.

14. The tool reads the form data inside a fillable (dynamic) DD Form 254: Item 10 and 11 boxes and their Other text, Item 12 routing and release authority, Item 13, Items 14 and 15, the Item 16 GCA details, Item 18 boxes and 18f addresses, and the form's UNCLASSIFIED or CUI marking.
15. Item 3 sets the template's source: Original, the numbered Revision, or Final, with its date. A Final starts the retention clock described above, exactly as if you had set it by hand.
16. A preview lists what will be imported and names the template after the received form's contract number and source. Nothing is saved until you confirm.
17. The import creates one DD-254 Template Language entry and nothing else. It does not create a draft or a dashboard card, does not link to any DD-254, and does not keep the PDF. The audit log records the file name and its SHA-256 fingerprint.

Items 1 to 9 and 17, reviewers, signatures and file attachments are not imported. The template holds the received form's own wording: review it before applying it to a subcontract, and remember that a prime may not impose some requirements on a subcontractor without GCA approval.

Some files cannot be imported, and the tool says why: a flattened, printed or scanned PDF, or one produced by another system, carries no form data; an encrypted PDF cannot be read; and a form marked above CUI is refused, because this tool handles UNCLASSIFIED and CUI entries only.

5.5 Contract Type templates

A Contract Type template holds exactly the same content as a DD-254 Template Language entry, and is built in the same editor. The two differ only in *when* they are used: a Contract Type is offered as a whole when you create a draft, and can be applied later from the Contract type dropdown on the card; a Template Language entry is inserted piece by piece from the form's side panel.

18. Dashboard, then Templates, then Contract Type, then **Add** — or **Capture from form** to snapshot a form you have already built.

Applying one ticks the Item 10, 11 and 18 boxes, sets the Item 12 routing and its office, fills 14, 15 and 16, and writes Block 13 — the free text first, then the language attached to each ticked box. Its required attachments appear in the attachment reminder and again in the distribution dialog, exactly as a Template Language entry's do.

Applying a whole Contract Type replaces each represented section, including blank fields and unchecked boxes. Applying it over a form with Item 13 text asks first.

Prime contract and task order metadata support DD-254 Template Language organisation. A prime number fills Item 2a only when empty. An order fills the effort field. New captures retain its type and the outgoing order-specific selection separately; legacy templates without that selection retain their earlier behavior. A prime alone does not create an order.

Contract Type templates saved by an earlier build held only a name and Block 13 text. That text now sits in the Block 13 field of the fuller editor and everything else starts empty; nothing was lost, and the entries keep working as they did.

5.6 Standard Language

Some organisations put the same wording on every DD-254 they issue. This library keeps that text in one place so it goes on identically every time, instead of being retyped or pasted from the last form.

19. A **Name** and the **text**, plus an optional **programme** and **Item 1a level**. The two optional fields exist only so the right entry can be offered when standard language is mandatory; blank means the entry fits any programme or any level. The programme options come from your Security Manager templates.
20. **While standard language is Optional, nothing is applied automatically.** The form's side panel lists your saved entries; you pick one and click **Insert**. Organisations keep several and use different ones on different contracts.
21. **Set to Mandatory in Settings** (2.5), the entry that fits is inserted for you. The programme comes from the language applied to the DD-254, which takes it from the Security Manager template; the level comes from **Item 1a**. When exactly one entry matches, it goes to the top of Item 13 as soon as the form carries both. When two match, neither is inserted and the blocking error names both, because which one applies is your judgement, not the tool's.

22. Inserted text goes to the very top of Block 13 — above the Item 10 and 11 box language and above anything you have typed.
23. Insert more than one and they read in the order you added them.
24. The same entry cannot be inserted twice. The panel marks what is already in Block 13.

Removing standard language is a **manual edit**: delete it from Block 13 yourself. Once deleted it stays deleted — nothing puts it back on the next validation pass. This is ordinary text once inserted, not a region the tool maintains.

What a DD-254 is carrying shows on its card, under the attachment list. It is there so you can see it without opening the form. While standard language is Optional it never blocks a status; set to Mandatory, a DD-254 whose Item 13 carries none of the library wording cannot leave Draft, and the error names what to insert. An empty library says so rather than demanding the impossible. The finding can be set aside with a written reason like any other (4.17).

Capture from form strips it. If you capture a form that has standard language showing, the captured template holds only what you wrote. Otherwise the text would be baked into that template untracked, and the same wording could later be inserted a second time and print twice on an issued form.

25. **Insert all** in the DD-254 Template Language panel does not touch this library.
26. In the full backup. Not in the spreadsheet round trip, and not in dashboard search.
27. **The panel shows what this DD-254 calls for.** Once the form has a programme — from the DD-254 template or contract type applied to it — and an **Item 1a** level, the panel lists only the entries written for those, with a line saying which. **Show all** opens the rest and comes back; each row shows the programme and level it is written for. Until the form has both, every entry is listed and the panel says what would narrow it.

5.7 Spreadsheet round trip

Every library except Standard Language exports to CSV and re-imports from CSV or XLSX.

28. Export first, even from an empty library — the header row is the layout the importer expects.
29. Edit in Excel. Keep the header row and the ID column; the ID is how a row is matched rather than duplicated.
30. Upload. Nothing is applied yet: a preview reports what will be updated, added, skipped and unmatched.
31. Confirm. Deleting unmatched entries is offered but guarded — removing more than half the list makes you type DELETE.
32. **Undo last change** reverts it. One level only.

Row 1 of an exported CSV carries the classification marking. The importer skips it automatically, so exported files re-import unchanged.

5.8 Saving Item 13 language back to a template

Wording you have refined on a form can be pushed back into the library it came from. Choose the template first — saving with none chosen, or with nothing to save, is refused. Item 11 language lands in the Item 11 map and Item 10 language in the Item 10 map; they do not cross.

If the template already holds language for that item you are asked before it is replaced, and declining leaves it alone. Saving the same wording twice does not prompt, because nothing would change. In sections layout the save button on a section box saves the text actually in that box.

5.9 Security Classification Guides

Item 13 has to identify the classification guides that apply, and every guide it cites has to reach the contractor. The DD Form 254 instructions ask for the applicable guides with page numbers or other designations, for the unclassified titles or identities of the guides, and for every referenced document to be attached or forwarded under separate cover. This library keeps those details once, so the same guide is cited the same way on every form.

> Enter only unclassified titles and identifiers. The library holds references to guides, never the guides themselves.

33. Open **Templates**, then **Security Classification Guides**, and add one row per guide: unclassified title, identifier, date, issuing office, an optional distribution statement, and whether the guide is attached or forwarded under separate cover. The library also imports and exports by spreadsheet and travels in template packs and Full Backup.
34. To tie a guide to contracts, use **+ Link a contract** on its row and pick from your DD-254 Template Language entries; link as many as apply. Each linked contract shows as a chip with its prime contract number; the ✕ on a chip unlinks it. A link survives renaming the contract template. A linked template that is not in this browser, for example after importing a colleague's guides without their contracts, is shown as such rather than dropped.
35. On the form, the **Security Classification Guides** section of the Checklist & Templates panel lists every guide. Guides linked to this draft's contract come first, marked **Linked to this contract**. The draft's contract is the DD-254 Template Language entry applied to it, or the one whose prime contract number matches Item 2a, ignoring spaces, hyphens and case. Linking only orders and marks the list: you still choose what to cite. **Cite** asks for the applicable portions (optional) and adds one line to Item 13, after your text and above the classified mailing addresses and the CUI block.

```
Security Classification Guide: Programme ALDER Security Classification Guide
(SCG-ALD-01), dated 2026-02-02, Programme ALDER Office; applicable portions: Sections
3-5. Attached.
```

36. A cited guide shows **cited in Item 13** and cannot be cited twice. The citation is ordinary text: edit or delete it as you would any other line.
37. Cited guides are named individually in the attachment reminder and in the distribution dialog. The generic reminder for Item 11c appears only while no guide is cited.

When a guide is reissued, change its date in the library. Any draft you open that still cites the old date shows a warning naming both dates, and its panel entry offers **Update citation**, which rewrites that guide's line with the new details and keeps the portions you entered. Confirm which version applies to the contract before updating. The warning never blocks a status, and records that are already Issued are not changed.

> A citation is matched to a library guide by its identifier, or by its title when the guide has no identifier. Matching is exact: guide SCG-1 is never confused with SCG-10.

6. Producing the form

Export	Use
Official DD-254 (PDF)	The official expanding XFA form. It is watermarked DRAFT while errors remain and signs in Acrobat Pro — see 6.2.
Preparer's Worksheet	Internal checklist of what is required, recommended and outstanding.

Export	Use
Contracting Officer Review Package	A preparatory checklist for the government contracting officer or, for a subcontract, the prime contractor: eligibility, safeguarding, guidance, distribution, and clause or flow-down review. On screen or as a PDF.
Print	Browser print of the on-screen form.

6.1 Contracting Officer Review Packages

There are two packages because two different people review a DD Form 254. The **Government CO / GCA review** is for a contracting officer placing a prime contract. The **Prime subcontract review** is for a prime contractor issuing a DD Form 254 to a subcontractor. Each carries only its own reader's actions.

In the government review only	In the prime subcontract review only
The GCA's biennial review of the security classification requirements (DoDM 5220.32 Volume 1, paragraph 6.3.g)	Confirming GCA authorization before imposing classified requirements on the subcontractor
Issuing a new DD Form 254 at award when the form is for a solicitation	Item 17e prime CAGE and Item 18b subcontractor FSO distribution
The contract clause applicability review	Subcontract flow-down: items needing GCA approval before a prime may impose them, and clause flow-down
	The SAP subcontract signature, SAP and IR&D; subcontract notices, and the flow-down ceiling against a prime DD-254

Everything else, such as eligibility and safeguarding checks, Item 13, SAP, SCI, CNWDI, NATO and CUI actions, Items 12, 14 and 15, distribution and the certifying official, is in both, word for word.

1. Choose **Contracting Officer Review Package** in the export menu. If Item 2b or 7a names a subcontract the prime subcontract review is selected; otherwise the government review is. The dialog says which and why.
2. Choose **view** to open it on screen or **PDF** to download it. You can pick the other audience in the same dialog.
3. Every page of the PDF carries the form's marking at the top and bottom, the package and audience, the draft title, contract number and stage, the tool release, the date generated and the page number. A page separated from the rest still says what it is and that it is not the DD Form 254. Exporting a PDF is written to the audit log.

Each package is a **preparatory review aid**, not an official form and not a substitute for the signed DD Form 254 or the contract file. It checks entity eligibility and safeguarding capability separately; Item 12 public-release routing; Item 13 clarity, currency and supporting documents; CUI contract direction; original, revised, final and solicitation actions; Items 14 and 15; and minimum signed distribution.

> The government package's clause section is an **applicability review**, not a complete clause matrix. A DD Form 254 box does not by itself prescribe a FAR or DFARS clause. The contracting officer must confirm the current regulation, agency supplement, acquisition type, COTS status, location and personnel facts, and actual subcontract performance before incorporating or flowing down clauses.

Neither package carries **signature or date lines**. Each lists the Item 17 certifying official's details and tells the signer to sign Item 17h and date Item 17i in the generated dynamic PDF. For a SAP subcontract — the SAP flag with a subcontractor in Item 2b or 7a — the prime subcontract review names the Item 7 subcontractor and states

that the subcontractor's authorised representative must sign. The form has no block for that signature and neither does the package: capture it however the programme accepts, then record where it is held with **Countersigned** on the card. Item titles in the package, such as Item 14 Additional Security Requirements and Item 15 Inspections, are read from the form.

For CUI, the requiring activity identifies the CUI through the contracting vehicle. If Controlled By, category, distribution statement or LDC, or the point of contact is missing, the package reports the gap and tells the reviewer to obtain written direction rather than invent a value.

6.2 Digital signatures

Open the generated dynamic PDF in Adobe Acrobat Pro and complete Items 17h Signature and 17i Date Signed there; the browser does not collect or prefill them. The export has been tested against a pristine blank copy of the form; both sign the same way.

> Acrobat Pro is what makes this work. The dynamic export loses the Adobe Reader Extensions that the official form ships with, because building the file rewrites it rather than appending to it. Reader Extensions are what let *free* Adobe Reader fill and sign a form; Acrobat Pro does not need them. So anyone in your chain signing on free Reader rather than Pro will not be able to sign the dynamic export.

4. If Acrobat reports that the operation failed while still appearing to sign, close the file and reopen it, then check the signature panel actually lists the signature. Persisting a signature means writing to the file, and that write can fail when the PDF was opened straight from a download or temporary location. Save it to a normal folder and sign from there.

XFA is unsupported in browser and mobile PDF viewers, so open the official export in Adobe Acrobat rather than judging it in a browser preview. The former user-facing flattened export was removed; its old static builder remains test-only and is not a release output.

6.3 How exported files are named

Exports are named from the form — CAGE codes, the contract number, the stage. A slash in a contract number becomes a hyphen, so **12/32** is filed as **12-32** rather than being squashed to 1232, which would be a different contract number and would collide with a form genuinely numbered 1232.

5. Spaces are packed out of PDF names and kept as underscores where words matter. Characters that carry no meaning in a contract number — colons, asterisks, question marks — are dropped.

> Files exported before this behaviour existed keep their old names; nothing is renamed retrospectively.

6.4 Consistent output formatting

The official dynamic PDF and the internal regression builder use one shared set of formatters. The second path is retained only as an independent test oracle, so the suite can catch a field that would otherwise print differently without exposing a second official export to users.

Field	How it prints
Items 1a and 1b	Words, not shouting, and no instruction text: Top Secret, Secret, Confidential, None, N/A.
All dates	YYYY-MM-DD. Anything that is not eight digits passes through untouched, so “see contract” still prints.

Field	How it prints
Phone numbers 16e and 17f	Digits only. Punctuation and a leading 1 are stripped; anything that is not a ten-digit number prints as typed.
CAGE codes 6b, 7b, 8b, 17e	Uppercase. The on-screen boxes also display uppercase as you type.
Item 13 text	Smart quotes, curly apostrophes, em dashes and ellipses are folded to plain characters that the PDF fonts can actually draw.
Reviewing officials	Internal reviewers are never printed. Only when there are more than six does an “Additional reviewing officials” line appear in Item 13.

If a printed value looks wrong, fix it on the form rather than in the PDF. The official export is always regenerated from the stored form fields.

6.5 Choosing how exported files are named

Manage then **Settings** lets you build the export file name from the fields your organisation files by. The default reproduces the previous fixed convention exactly, so leaving it alone changes nothing.

- Pick which boxes contribute, in what order, and which separator joins them. Items 6b, 7b and 8b are each offered on their own.
- An empty box is skipped without leaving a separator behind, and if every box is empty the name falls back rather than producing an empty one.
- Each box contributes at most 30 characters, and only the first line of a multi-line box, so a long combination still fits a usable path.
- Hyphens inside a contract number are preserved rather than eaten by the separator.

A company that files by contract number alone, or by CAGE alone, can have exactly that. Corrupt or unrecognised stored settings fall back to the default instead of breaking the export.

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7. Manager functions

7.1 Manager rollup

Because each person's tool is a separate island, managers consolidate by collecting Full Backup files and importing them together under **Manager Rollup**. The result is read-only and held only for that session — nothing is written into your own workspace, and closing the view discards it.

7.2 Portfolio CSV

A row per DD-254 with the full picture: stage, status, contract, contractor, clearance and safeguarding levels, CAGE, GCA, every Item 10 and 11 selection, error and warning counts, NISS, countersignature, issue and review dates, distribution count, open holds and their reasons, and the cancellation date, source status and reason.

This answers *which of our contracts involve X*. Filter the 10a or 11i column in Excel and you have every contract with COMSEC or TEMPEST without opening a draft. Cancelled work is included even though the dashboard hides it.

7.3 Notes report and audit log

The **Notes Report** is a printable per-draft summary of holds, to-do items and notes. The **Audit Log** records every material action — status changes, holds, cancellations, NISS verification, distribution, template uploads, restores, recounts — with timestamps, and exports to CSV.

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8. Data safety

8.1 Full backup

Templates, then **Full Backup** writes a single JSON file containing every template library, every draft, and the audit log. The dashboard header counts changes since your last backup and turns red when you are behind.

After the download starts, the tool asks whether the Full Backup finished and was saved successfully. Only the backed-up changes clear when you confirm; later edits keep their reminder. Choose Cancel if the browser blocked the download, it is still running, or you cannot find the file; the reminder stays active.

Backups carry a SHA-256 checksum and entry counts. On restore both are verified: a truncated download or an edited file is refused rather than silently loaded. Older backups without a checksum require explicit confirmation. The audit log merges on restore rather than overwriting, de-duplicated by timestamp.

Restore checks the file first, then shows what it would change before anything is applied, library by library, the same way an import from a colleague does. Every library with a difference starts ticked, because it is your own backup; untick any you want to leave alone.

In the backup	What happens
A template you still hold, changed since the backup	Returned to the backup’s version. Recognised by its hidden identifier, so a rename does not matter.
A template you have since deleted	Added back.
A different template with the same name as one of yours	**Both are kept.** Yours is untouched; the backup’s arrives renamed, for example *Mid-Atlantic CSO (imported, 2026-08-01)*.
Nothing — a template you created after the backup	Kept. A restore never removes a template.

Drafts in the backup are added or overwritten by ID; drafts that are not in it are kept. **Undo last change** in a library reverts what the restore did to it.

> **Replace all templates instead** makes every list exactly the backup’s, removing templates created or changed since. The tool first downloads a Full Backup of what you have now and asks whether it saved; if you say it did not, nothing is replaced.

8.2 Sharing templates with colleagues

When one person curates the libraries for a team, **Manage, then Share templates** moves them between instances. **Export templates only** writes a file containing the nine libraries and *nothing else* — no drafts, no dashboard, nothing about anybody’s actual DD-254s. The file is stamped with who exported it and when.

Export templates only opens a picker before it writes anything. Every library is listed with its entries, all ticked, so sharing the lot is still one click — but you can untick a whole library, or individual entries within one, and send only

what is useful. Sharing two new Standard Language paragraphs need not drag your entire facility list along with them.

1. A running count shows how many of your templates are selected. A partly ticked library shows as such. Selecting nothing is refused rather than writing an empty file.

Import templates from a colleague shows what would change before anything is applied, library by library, and you tick which to take.

What arrives	What happens
A template you imported before, since edited	Updated in place. Recognised by a hidden identifier, so it works even if either of you renamed it.
A template identical to one you already hold	Skipped silently. Not a conflict, and it does not clutter the preview.
A brand new template	Added.
The same NAME as one of yours, but different text and a different origin	**Both are kept.** Yours is untouched; theirs arrives renamed — for example *Bob (from Alice, 2026-08-08)*.

The last row is the only genuinely ambiguous case: two people independently created a template with the same name. Neither is more correct, so nothing is discarded. Delete whichever you do not want — that takes one click, whereas recovering wording that was silently overwritten takes a backup you may not have.

Facility and **Performance / Sub** are unticked by default. Those describe your own sites and your own subcontractors, so a curator's copy is usually wrong for everyone else. Tick them only if you mean to.

2. **Undo last change** in any library reverts that library's import. One level, as everywhere else.
3. Every import and export is written to the audit log, including who the pack came from.

8.3 Storage

The dashboard footer shows local storage in use. Drafts and templates live in the browser's local database; if that is unavailable the tool falls back to a much smaller store. If an individual draft write fails, the tool stops claiming that it was saved, keeps the newest emergency copy visible in the open tab, and shows a red **DRAFT NOT SAVED** warning that cannot be cleared by an unrelated successful transaction. Keep the tab open, take a Full Backup immediately, and free browser storage before continuing. Closing the tab loses anything held only in the emergency copy.

8.4 The audit log and chain of custody

The audit log is no longer capped at 5,000 entries and no longer competes for the small storage bucket — it lives in the drafts database. If a cap is ever reached, the log records that entries were removed rather than losing them silently.

Deleting a draft is recorded, and cancelling the confirmation records nothing. Deleting a record that has revisions or finals spawned from it warns you and names the descendants first.

A full backup carries its own checksum for the history, separate from the checksum over the form data, so an older backup still verifies.

8.5 Spreadsheet exports cannot carry formulas

Any cell that would otherwise begin with a character a spreadsheet treats as a formula is neutralised on export, and the guard is stripped on import, so a round trip through the tool preserves every value. An apostrophe you typed yourself is preserved. This applies to dismissal reasons and free text as much as to fields.

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9. A day with the tool

1. Open the tool in one tab. Check the backup indicator; if it is red, back up.
2. Scan the status chips. Work Blocked first — each carries a hold saying what it is waiting on, including any approval hold.
3. Open what needs action. Clear validation errors using the right-hand panel.
4. When a form is complete, verify the FCL in NISS and record it, then set Ready to sign.
5. On issue, record distribution when prompted. Attach everything the reminder lists, and send encrypted whenever the tool identifies CUI handling from the marking, selections, designation, LDCs or template.
6. Set the review date on revisions and take the calendar invite.
7. Back up before you close.

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10. Security posture

This matters if the tool has to pass a security review, and the short answer is that none of it has to be taken on trust.

1. **It makes no network requests of its own.** The file contains no fetch, XMLHttpRequest, WebSocket, EventSource or sendBeacon call site, and loads nothing from the internet — no remote scripts, styles, fonts or images. One feature is a deliberate exception: the SAM.gov lookup opens a search URL carrying a value taken from the form.
2. **The browser constrains it**, rather than the tool merely asserting it. A Content Security Policy in the file's header sets **connect-src 'none'**, so the browser refuses fetch, XMLHttpRequest, WebSocket and sendBeacon whatever the code attempts, and **form-action 'none'** blocks posting anywhere. Two limits matter: the policy does not stop injected script, because the whole application is inline, and it does not cover ordinary navigation. Exfiltration is constrained, not blocked.
3. **It executes no dynamic code.** No eval, no new Function. The policy deliberately omits 'unsafe-eval'.
4. **It installs nothing.** No administrator rights, no registry entries, no services, no scheduled tasks. It is a document opened in a browser tab.
5. **Data stays on the machine**, in browser IndexedDB with localStorage as a fallback. There is no account, no licence check and no telemetry.

Reference hyperlinks to public government sites — acquisition.gov, dcsa.mil, esd.whs.mil and others — open only when you click them. The page itself never contacts them.

> The file embeds an unmodified open-source PDF library, the official dynamic DD Form 254 PDF and a flattened derivative used by internal verification. The flat derivative is not the original Government download. BUILD_FACTS.md and the security fact sheet provide current sizes, hashes and provenance; the rebuild kit verifies reconstruction from the extracted parts.

Accessibility. Every form control carries an accessible name, and the Item 10, 11 and 18 names are read from the form at runtime so a screen reader hears exactly what is printed beside the box. Interactive elements are keyboard operable.

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11. Notes and limitations

11.1 On cited rules and advisory findings

The validation alerts and the two advisors identify the source used for each comparison. SAP-specific requirements attributed to DoDM 5205.07 appear only when the SAP DD-254 flag is on. The citations make a finding reviewable; they do not make the tool a substitute for the contract, the GCA, NISS, the responsible Government security authority, or the current text of the cited source.

Advisor findings are deliberately conservative prompts. A potential contradiction may have a documented fact or authority outside the DD Form 254 that resolves it. Verify the operational answer and retain that evidence rather than treating the screen as an eligibility determination.

11.2 What the tool does not do

- It does not track DD Forms 254 *received* from customers, only those you issue. Importing a received form creates a template entry and nothing else — see 5.4.
- It does not treat contract completion as creating a Final or authorizing retention; disposition and any continued requirements need their own evidence.
- A copy carries the form and the NISS verification; **Copy** also carries the notes and to-dos. Neither kind carries the original's status, holds, distribution record, countersignature or dates.

11.3 Keeping this manual honest

This manual is generated from a content file and a build script kept alongside the PDF. Every release that changes the HTML must update this source and rebuild both published copies of the manual; never patch the PDF by hand.

11.4 Hosting remains a separate future phase

This release is one self-contained HTML file. The optional future Docker/Kubernetes phase is not included. No account service, application server, shared record database, automatic policy feed or collaborative approval service has been introduced.